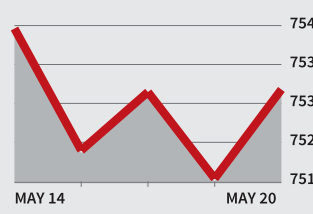


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 75318.39 (+117.54)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23659.00	+41.00
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.33	+0.03
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.86	+0.33
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	157920.00	-520
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	267302.00	-1411

AGAINST THE GRAIN

Rice prices in the global market will likely rise due to the balance swinging to a deficit after over a decade **p10**



TECHNOPHILE

OnePlus Pad 4 is a natural evolution with more power and extra improvements **p4**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

NEW VENTURE

TSF Group, Bosch JV to make air systems for CVs



Chennai: TSF Group (Wheels India Ltd and Brakes India Pvt Ltd) and Bosch are planning a 50:50 joint venture to make electronic-controlled and software driven modules for air compression, air processing, air suspension and air parking brakes for commercial vehicles (trucks and buses). The JV seeks to combine Bosch's strengths in electronics & software, sensing and control systems with the mechanical system design, manufacturing capabilities of Brakes India and Wheels India. **P2**

Punjab & Sind Bank
If you service is a part of life.

CAR LOAN
PSB Apna Vahan

7.30%* ROI

GIVE A MISSED CALL ON **8879840089**

PSBs step up hiring of apprentices to cut costs

COST-EFFECTIVE. Banks are using them for marketing, outreach and digital roles

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The hiring priorities of public sector banks are undergoing a structural shift, with graduate apprentices emerging as a low-cost choice, partly substituting the much-coveted regular clerical positions.

Data on recent recruitment trends show that banks are increasingly using apprentices to meet their manpower requirement arising from the expansion of marketing, customer outreach and digital banking operations. This is resulting in substantial cost savings.

While apprenticeship has traditionally been associated with public sector undertakings, the model is now gaining traction in the banking sector. Of late, several public sector banks have stepped up the hiring of apprentices.

WIN-WIN MODEL

"The apprenticeship model has now become an important workforce strategy in the



banking sector as a win-win for banks as well as job seekers," Srinath Gattu, Zonal Head-South, BFSI Sector Skill Council (BFSI-SSC), the nodal agency for recruitment of apprentices, told *businessline*.

"For graduates, it offers hands-on experience, industry exposure and role-based learning, thereby improving employability. For banks, it reduces pressure on existing staff and bridges workforce gaps until permanent recruitment is completed," he said.

The State Bank of India and Union Bank of India are now recruiting 7,150 and 1,800 apprentices, respectively. Other PSBs, including Bank of Baroda, Punjab National Bank, Central Bank of

Hiring trends

Year	Clerks	Apprentices
2023-24	12,608	11,600
2024-25	19,863	14,854
2025-26	17,274	18,953
2026-27 (till date)	8,950	26,000 (Expected)

Collated from data of banks, BFSI-SSC

India, Union Bank of India, Indian Overseas Bank, UCO Bank and Bank of India, are also deploying apprentices for ground operations, customer service, credit processing, collections, branch support and digital banking functions.

MONTHLY STIPEND

Apprentices, aged between 20 and 28, are paid a monthly stipend of ₹15,000-20,000, depending on the place of posting — metros, tier-I or tier-II cities. Of this, ₹4,500 per month is reimbursed to the banks by the Centre.

In contrast, a newly recruited clerk in a public sector bank, draws an initial monthly salary of over ₹40,000, apart from allowances, medical benefits and

retirement-linked benefits.

A senior SBI official said apprentice hiring had enabled significant cost optimisation, adding that the bank had not discontinued recruitment for clerical and probationary officer positions. "It is designed primarily for fresh and unemployed graduates as a strategic entry point into a banking career," he added.

FULL-TIME ROLES

CS Vepa, former Director of the National School of Banking, Hyderabad, and current Director of Vepa Academy, said SBI already provides weightage to apprentices during recruitment for full-time positions. "Other banks should also extend similar weightage to apprentices," he said.

Job-seekers are also upbeat about it. "This is real-time work, and the exposure has made me more confident about pursuing a long-term career in banking," said MR Mohan, a B.Com graduate working as an apprentice with IOB.

NCDEX pilots derivative product based on Mumbai's rainfall

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The National Commodity and Derivatives Exchange (NCDEX), in partnership with the India Meteorological Department and IIT-Bombay, has launched a pilot futures contract tied to Mumbai's rainfall.

The exchange on Wednesday introduced RAINMUMBAI, a rainfall index that measures deviations from the city's 30-year Long-Period Average (LPA) rainfall.

Four monthly futures contracts, beginning May 29, will be available for trading, allowing market participants to take positions based on expectations of excess or deficient rainfall during the monsoon season.

BASE VALUE

The Index will debut at a base value of 2,206 points, derived from historical rainfall data. Rainfall above the LPA will push the index higher, while a rainfall deficit will drag it lower.

Globally, this is the first derivatives contract based on the monsoon; the Chicago Mercantile Ex-

change offers standardised temperature and snowfall contracts for cities worldwide. "Like all derivative contracts, RAINMUMBAI is available for trade by any market participant," said Kedar Deshpande, Chief Business Officer at NCDEX.

"The monsoon arrives first in Mumbai, and then spreads across central and western India. Farmers can take RAINMUMBAI as a reference to hedge their financial risk on account of excess or low rainfall estimate. For a farmer anywhere in India, a correlation or reference hedge can be used to establish the hedge position," said Deshpande.

LOT SIZE

Each contract will have a lot size linked to ₹50 per millimetre of rainfall, translating into an initial contract value of about ₹1.1 lakh. With margins fixed at 10-12 per cent, traders would need to set aside roughly ₹12,000 per lot.

The contract will be cash settled on expiry. The exchange will introduce a liquidity enhancement scheme to ensure liquidity at the initial stage. As a powerful risk management tool,

the product will be useful for a wide range of investors, including power utilities, banks with agriculture loan portfolios and taxi aggregator. Arun Raste, MD and CEO, NCDEX, said the exchange is working on the easterly monsoon, and a move is on to launch other heat products to complete its offerings in the weather basket.

RAINCHENNAI COMING

NCDEX will introduce a product on the easterly monsoon under RAINCHENNAI, he said. This will be built using daily rainfall data provided by the IMD.

Under other insurance products, weather derivatives are settled purely on observed data, eliminating the need for loss assessment and a faster settlement cycle, besides greater operational efficiency.

Bikram Singh, Head, Regional Meteorological Centre, Mumbai, said RAINMUMBAI will serve as a broad ecosystem of participants across India's weather sensitive sectors, including agriculture and allied sectors, power and energy, financial institutions, logistics and transport.

Dayanidhi Maran, son to unveil mobile streaming platform soon

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Chennai Central MP and former Union Minister Dayanidhi Maran, along with his son Karan, is getting set to launch a new digital entertainment business.

businessline has learnt that the venture will be in a new format, which has not been explored before in the Tamil entertainment sector, and will be smartphone-led, in line with the latest trends.

The business is set for an official launch as early as the end of May, sources said.

NEW MARAN GROUP

Dayanidhi is said to have set up a new company, Maran Group, that brings together diverse businesses under one umbrella.

The first venture rolling



Karan Maran

out of the company's stable is set to be a mobile-led streaming platform. Sources said it will be in the form of a niche streaming platform which, among other content, will focus on short dramas.

The venture will be spearheaded by Executive Director Karan Dayanidhi Maran with Dayanidhi as the Chairman, and media exec-

utive Mohamed Israth as the Group CEO, sources said.

Karan is the founder of Cloutgency, Kadhai Shorts, KKIX Customs and CHA Wellness, and his ventures span digital marketing, media storytelling, automotive lifestyle culture, and wellness.

Dayanidhi did not elaborate on *businessline's* queries, but confirmed his son was involved in a new venture.

The entry of Dayanidhi and his family in the entertainment business is significant, given the events that unfolded last year when Dayanidhi and his brother Kalanithi got into a legal battle over their stake in the entertainment company Sun TV Network. The feud was later settled through mediation in the presence of key DMK leaders, including MK Stalin.

Rupee at lifetime low of 96.86 against the dollar

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Declining for the ninth consecutive session, the rupee depreciated 16 paise to close at a fresh lifetime low of 96.86 against the US dollar on Wednesday as elevated global crude prices amid the West Asia crisis stoked inflation worries.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.89 against the US dollar, then lost further ground to touch a record low of 96.95. It went up to the day's high of 96.65 before settling at a fresh all-time low of 96.86 against the greenback, registering a fall of 16 paise over its previous close.

In the previous session, the rupee tumbled 50 paise to settle at 96.70 against the dollar.

See also **p9**

RAINS ARE COMING



MONSOON WATCH. Waves crash at the Fort Kochi beach on Wednesday. The South-West monsoon is expected to set in early over Kerala on May 26, said the India Meteorological Department last week. With the monsoon expected next week, eight NDRF teams will be deployed in the State as part of preparedness, said the Kerala State Disaster Management Authority. **THULASI KAKKAT**

How Melodi turned it a viral moment for Melody

A marketing coup for Parle as Modi gifts the toffee to his Italian counterpart Meloni

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

A video of Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifting a pack of home-grown toffee brand Melody to Italian PM Giorgia Meloni, ahead of the high-level bilateral engagement between the two nations, took the Internet by storm and handed the brand owned by Parle Products a viral moment.

'Melodi' was a moniker coined by internet users and meme makers in 2023 following the two leaders' friendly engagements during G20 and COP28 events.

But it catapulted into the mainstream when the Italian PM hashtagged it, posting a selfie with the Indian PM at COP28 with the caption, "Good friends at COP28, #Melodi."

On Wednesday, the two

leaders' viral video, which amassed over 8 million views within hours on X, was a playful nod to that viral Melodi meme.

But the real winner was Melody toffees, known for its iconic tagline, *Melody Itni Chocolatey Kyun hai. Melody khao khud jaan jao*, and positioning of "sweetening relationships since 1983".

A SWEET SURPRISE

Mayank Shah, Vice-President, Parle Products, told *businessline* that it was a pleasant surprise for the company, and Modi with his gesture had taken the brand Melody onto the global stage.

"We already export Melody to over 100 countries, and it is among the top confectionery brands in India. We expect this viral



A video of Modi gifting a pack of Melody to Italian PM Giorgia Meloni has gone viral

moment to accelerate our growth not just in India, but also in terms of exports. This gives us a huge opportunity to go all out and make a mark on the global stage," he added.

Quick-commerce plat-

form Blinkit said in an X post that it was seeing a spike in search for Melody on its app. "Confectionery brands spend billions trying to capture a permanent slice of consumer consciousness. For Parle, the ultimate case of earned media value just played out in Rome, completely free of charge. It is a great example of how geopolitical soft power can instantly amplify a domestic brand onto the global stage. For Parle Products, this moment offers a great top-of-the-mind boost, cementing Melody onto the public consciousness, through a high-profile association with two heads of state. Also, the opportunity to premiumise a mass market impulse product," said Lloyd Mathias, Independent Director and Business Strategist.

Tracking prices and deals, Google's AI-powered 'Universal Cart' will reshape how you shop online

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Google's decision to embed an AI-powered, persistent shopping cart across Search, Gemini, YouTube and Gmail marks its most aggressive attempt yet to reclaim the product discovery layer it lost to marketplaces over the past decade.

Industry executives say the implications for India's e-commerce stack could be significant.

MULTIPLE SELLERS

The feature, unveiled at Google I/O, allows users to add products from multiple sellers into a single Google-managed cart, with real-time price tracking, deal comparison and stock alerts built in. The architecture is deliberately transactional.

Google is no longer positioning itself as a search referral engine that directs

consumers to platforms, but as the commerce layer itself.

For marketplaces, the threat is structural. Deep Bajaj, Re-Founder and CEO of Sirona Hygiene, said the risk cuts to the core of what platforms have spent years building.

"The battle may shift from who has inventory to who owns consumer intent and data," he said.

"If checkout and transaction move to a Google layer, marketplaces may increasingly become fulfilment and logistics infrastructure while losing direct relationships, repeat behaviour and loyalty loops."

Satish Meena, Advisor at Datum Intelligence, provided the historical context.

"Over the last six-seven years, product discovery shifted from Google to marketplaces because consumers started relying on reviews, pricing and fulfilment



ecosystems," he said. "Now, Google wants to reclaim that discovery layer by combining AI, price intelligence and personalised recommendations."

The open question, he added, is behavioural — whether Indian consumers will extend transactional trust to an AI-led checkout flow, given that merchant reliability remains a live purchase consideration in the

market. For D2C brands, the calculus is more nuanced. Rishav Jain, Managing Director and Co-Lead of the Consumer and Consumer Tech practice at Alvarez & Marsal India, flagged both an opportunity and a concentration risk.

"Product discovery and selection could potentially become significantly easier, time efficient and even more democratic," he said.

CONVERSATIONAL COM

"Depending on the intuitive accuracy of the platform, this could potentially provide a fillip to conversational commerce in India. Brands would need to enhance their online play book right across product listing, visibility and availability," he added, cautioning that digital marketing spends for D2C brands could become more concentrated as discovery increasingly shifts toward AI-led interfaces.

QUICKLY.
Bosch Q4 net profit rises 3% to ₹569 crore

Bengaluru: Bosch Ltd reported a 2.7 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) increase in net profit to ₹568.6 crore in the fourth quarter of FY26, compared with ₹553.6 crore in the corresponding quarter last year. Revenue from operations stood at ₹5,566 crore (€520 million) in Q4 FY26, up 13.3 per cent over the same quarter last year. The growth was driven by higher demand across the automotive market, including the two-wheeler segment. **OUR BUREAU**

Correction

In the report, “Governance cloud dogs Tata stocks; ₹10 lakh crore lost since September 2024” published on May 20, 2026, the decline in market capitalisation of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles between September 2024 and March 2026 was incorrectly stated as nearly 70 per cent. The calculation did not account for the demerger of Tata Motors and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles during the period. The combined market capitalisation decline of the two entities during the period was 29 per cent. The error is regretted.

Bombay House tightens grip around Jaguar Land Rover

PLAN OF ACTION. TaMo cuts JLR’s board from 13 to 3, eyes £1.7 b savings over 2 years

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Jaguar Land Rover’s decision to cut its operating board from 13 members to just three marks the most significant shift in Tata Motors’ stewardship of the British luxury carmaker since its 2008 acquisition from Ford.

For nearly two decades, the unwritten compact was simple: Bombay House provided capital and strategic patience, while JLR’s UK management retained broad autonomy over products, engineering and operations.

That arrangement is now giving way to a leaner, India-linked structure in which the JLR Ltd board comprises Chief Executive PB Balaji, Chief Financial Officer Richard Molyneux and Non-Executive Director Al-Noor Ramji.

A 13-member Executive Committee led by Balaji has been tasked with restoring profitability and cash generation.



CHANGING GEARS. CEO PB Balaji has been tasked with improving JLR’s cost base and financial consistency

The committee includes Chief Strategy Officer Balaje Rajan, China and procurement head Qing Pan, Chief Growth Officer Lennard Hoonrik, Chief Technology Officer Thomas Müller, Chief Programme Delivery Officer Steve Marsh, and Chief Information and Digital Officer Naveen Krishna, among others.

FY26 WAKE-UP CALL
The restructuring follows a difficult FY26 in which JLR swung to a net loss of about £244 million and burned roughly £2.2 billion in cash, hit by a cyberattack, higher US tariffs, weaker demand in

China and the transition costs of repositioning Jaguar as an all-electric brand.

“JLR remains the single most important driver of Tata Motors’ valuation, but it has also become the biggest source of earnings volatility,” said Kranthi Bathini, Equity Strategist at WealthMills Securities.

“The governance overhaul suggests the Tata Group wants the same level of operational discipline at JLR that helped revive Tata Motors’ India passenger vehicle business,” Bathini added.

Brokerages broadly echo that view.

Balaji, the first Tata Mo-

tors executive to lead JLR, has been tasked with resetting the company’s cost base and improving financial consistency.

The company is targeting £1.7 billion in savings over two years through what it calls “Enterprise Missions”, focused on reducing delivered costs, cutting warranty expenses and improving digital productivity, with the goal of bringing cash break-even volumes back toward 300,000 vehicles annually.

WHY JLR MATTERS

A JLR spokesperson said the Executive Committee, effective from April 2026, has been given “larger operational autonomy” and “stronger, simplified decision sub-groups” to enable faster decision-making.

Bathini said, “If Balaji succeeds in bringing JLR’s earnings back to a more stable trajectory, Tata Motors could benefit from stronger group cash flows, lower valuation uncertainty and improved investor confidence.”

TSF Group, Bosch plan JV for electronic air systems for CVs

Our Bureau
Chennai

TSF Group (Wheels India Ltd and Brakes India Pvt Ltd) and Bosch are planning to enter into a 50:50 joint venture for the development and manufacture of next-generation electronically-controlled air system products for commercial vehicles (trucks and buses) to be sold worldwide.

The JV will focus on engineering, manufacturing and sales of electronically-

controlled and software driven modules for air compression, air processing, air suspension and air parking brakes, a statement from the TSF Group said.

THE BEST OF BOTH
The proposed JV seeks to combine Bosch’s strengths in electronics and software, sensing and control systems with the mechanical system design, pneumatic management architecture and manufacturing capabilities available within Brakes India and Wheels India.



Srivats Ram, MD, Wheels India Ltd **BUJOY GHOSH**

“As part of the TSF Group, Wheels India has been a pioneer in air suspension systems for buses in India for

over three decades. Over this period, we have built strong relationships with both OEMs and end users through consistent product quality and service. We are pleased to collaborate with Bosch on this development initiative to advance electronic air suspension systems for the global customers,” said Srivats Ram, Chairman & Managing Director, Wheels India.

TSF has expertise in hardware and Bosch in software and electronics. Further, Wheels India and Brakes India have domain engineering

capabilities in the products. The investment details will be worked out later, Ram told *businessline*.

Wheels India is a leading manufacturer of wheels for trucks, agricultural tractors, passenger vehicles and construction equipment, air suspension systems for trucks and buses, and industrial components for the construction and windmill industry with manufacturing plants in Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Andhra Pradesh, the release said.

Grasim Industries Q4 net up 28%

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Grasim Industries, an Aditya Birla Group company, has reported 28 per cent increase in March quarter net profit at ₹3,802 crore against ₹2,973 crore in the year-ago period, on the back of better realisations.

Revenue was up at ₹51,101 crore (₹44,267 crore). EBITDA increased 22 per cent to ₹8,011 crore. The company has announced a dividend of ₹10 a share.

BIZ-WISE BREAKUP

The revenue of cellulosic staple fibre business grew 14 per cent to ₹4,614 crore, with EBITDA doubling to ₹588 crore led by higher volume and benign pulp prices.

Despite the rescinding of the Quality Control Order, domestic CSF prices stood higher due to rupee depreciation and partial passing of higher sulphur prices.

Revenue from chemicals

Scorecard (in ₹ cr)		
	Q4 FY26	Q4 FY25
Revenue	51,101	44,267
Net profit	3,802	2,973
EPS (diluted) (₹)	28.84	22.19

business segment was up by 7 per cent y-o-y at ₹2,458 crore and EBITDA increased 3 per cent to ₹304 crore due to better profitability in caustic and chlorine derivatives.

The building materials segment reported its highest-ever quarterly revenue at ₹30,042 crore, up 19 per cent y-o-y led by robust performance across cement, paints and B2B e-commerce businesses. EBITDA grew by 22 per cent to ₹5,386 crore on the back of higher profitability in cement business (UltraTech).

This was partially offset by initial expenses for building ‘Birla Opus’ in the decorative paints business.

Birla Opus gained market share increased 90 bps

quarter-on-quarter (q-o-q), reinforcing its number three position in the organised decorative paints segment, said the company.

PRICING POINTS

Strategic pricing actions were undertaken over March quarter and continued in June quarter, narrowing the gap with the industry players and to offset the raised input costs due to volatile environment. Despite price increases, company maintains its resolve, to sustain market share gains and deliver guided revenues.

Birla Pivot revenue more than doubled on a y-o-y basis. Aditya Birla Capital reported 10 per cent revenue growth at ₹13,422 crore driven by robust lending and insurance businesses.

In FY26, the company’s net profit was up 33 per cent at ₹10,300 crore (₹7,756 crore) while revenue increased 18 per cent to ₹1,75,431 crore (₹1,48,478 crore)

ASK Automotive bets on aluminium components as segment grows 30% in FY26, overtakes brakes biz

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

ASK Automotive is using the cash flows from its dominant two-wheeler braking business to fund the next phase of its expansion, as it transforms from India’s largest two-wheeler brake supplier into a more diversified maker of lightweight aluminium auto components and EV-ready precision-engineered parts.

ALPS SEGMENT

It reported consolidated total income of ₹4,196.2 crore in FY26, up 16.2 per cent from ₹3,612.7 crore in FY25, while EBITDA rose 24.1 per cent to ₹550.9 crore from ₹443.8 crore and net profit increased 20.1 per cent to ₹297.3 crore from ₹247.6 crore.

The Gurugram-based company said underlying net



TOUCHING THE SUMMIT. The most significant development in FY26 was the rise of ALPS as ASK’s largest business **PERIASAMY M**

revenue grew 20.1 per cent. ASK’s Aluminium Lightweighting Precision Solutions (ALPS) division grew 30 per cent to ₹2,121 crore in FY26 from ₹1,632 crore in FY25, overtaking its flagship braking business to become the company’s largest segment and contributing 50.8 per cent of consolidated revenue.

Chairman and Managing Director Kuldip Singh Rathee said FY26 marked

VISUALLY.

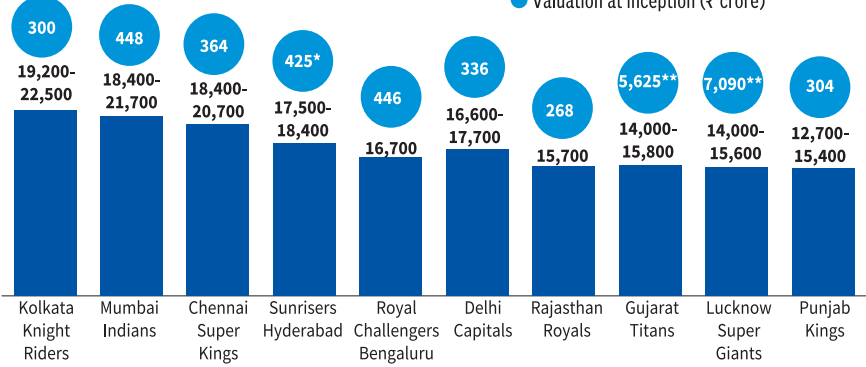
Compiled by Yashaswani Chauhan | Graphic: Visveswaran V

IPL economy

Cricket continues to remain at the centre of India’s professional sports economy through its unmatched scale, star power and franchise strength. Fanatic Sports Hurun India’s Most Valuable Sports Teams 2026 Report shows that IPL still has India’s most experienced athlete pool, the country’s longest-playing sports stars and some of the strongest franchise success stories

IPL franchisees grow manifold in valuations

Top 10 most valuable franchises 2026



* Base valuation corresponds to the franchise’s inception in 2012 ** Base valuation corresponds to the franchise’s inception in 2021

Investors in IPL teams are raking in the moolah

Team name	Exited investors	Exit multiple
Rajasthan Royals	Lachlan Murdoch	92.1x
Rajasthan Royals	Blenheim Chalcot (Manoj Badale)	24.3x
Rajasthan Royals	RedBird Capital	7.8x
Royal Challengers Bengaluru	United Spirits (Diageo)	37.2x
Gujarat Titans	CVC Capital Partners*	1.3x

*Partially exited its stake

Several large groups now in the business of sports

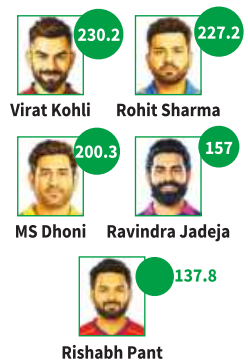
Major owners across Indian sports leagues

Owner	Teams owned	Sports presence
GMR Group	10	Cricket, kabaddi, kho-kho
JSW Group	7	Cricket, football, hockey, kabaddi
Reliance Industries	6	Cricket
RPSG Group	5	Cricket, football
Capri Sports	5	Cricket, football, kabaddi, kho-kho

IPL has created India’s highest-earning professional athletes

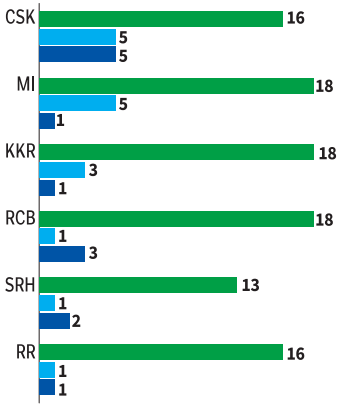
Top all-time IPL cumulative earners

● Total earned (₹ crore)



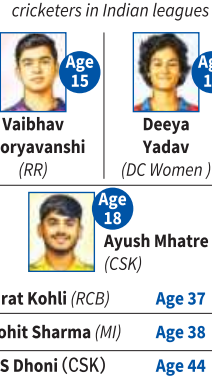
Chennai and Mumbai remain IPL’s benchmark franchises

■ Seasons played ■ Seasons won ■ Runners-up



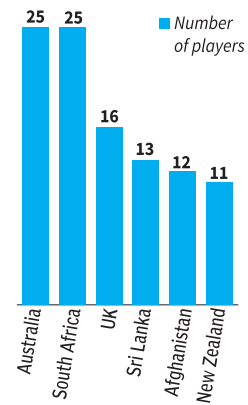
Teenage cricketers are entering the IPL younger than ever

Youngest and oldest cricketers in Indian leagues



Top foreign countries supplying players to Indian cricket leagues

■ Number of players



Source: Fanatic Sports Hurun India’s Most Valuable Sports Teams 2026 Report

Apollo Hospitals net profit up 36% at ₹529 crore

Our Bureau
Chennai

Apollo Hospitals reported 18 per cent growth in consolidated revenue for the quarter ended March 2026 (Q4 FY26) at ₹6,605 crore, with broad-based growth across the hospitals, diagnostics and digital health segments. Net profit for the quarter grew 36 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹529 crore.

For FY26, consolidated revenue grew 16 per cent y-o-y to ₹25,229 crore. Consol-

Scorecard (in ₹ crore)			
	Q4FY26	Q4FY25	YOY %
Revenue	6,605	5,592	18
PAT	529	390	36
EBITDA Margin (%)	15.30	13.77	153 bps

idated net profit grew 34 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,942 crore.

MATERNITY ENTITY

The board, in its meeting on Wednesday, also approved plans to combine Apollo Cradle & Fertility with Cloudnine, subject to CCI approval, to create a large maternity and fertility care entity. Under this, AHLL will divest its stake in Apollo Specialty Hospitals Pvt Ltd (ASHPL) and Apollo Fertility Centre Pvt Ltd (AFCPL) to Kids Clinic India (the company behind Cloudnine).

The value of the transaction will be ₹1,550 crore and will be executed through a combination of cash and 9.9

per cent stake in the combined entity.

Speaking to *businessline*, Madhu Sasidhar, President and CEO, Hospitals Division, Apollo, and Krishnan Akhileswaran, Group CFO, said all business segments and all markets have shown robust growth in the fiscal. The EBITDA margin of established hospital units stood at 25.5 per cent in Q4 FY26 versus 24.4 per cent in Q4 FY25, Akhileswaran said. “In Q4 FY26, the cash burn in our online business was also down indicating operational efficiencies,” he added.

Sasidhar said that interna-

Bangladesh is almost back to normal and that their international patients inflow has not taken a hit due to the West Asia war.

OTHER CHANNELS

Healthcare revenue for FY26 stood at ₹12,555 crore, a 13 per cent y-o-y growth. The retail healthcare and diagnostics arm, Apollo Health and Lifestyle, recorded 20 per cent revenue growth in the fiscal, and also narrowed its losses to ₹10 crore in FY26 versus loss of ₹27 crore in FY25.

Digital health arm Apollo HealthCo grew revenue at 19 per cent y-o-y in FY26, and net profit stood at ₹324 crore vs ₹47 crore in FY25.

As for the scheme to de-merge the pharmacy and digital health business and separately list it, the management expects it to close by the fourth quarter of FY27.

Jubilant FoodWorks consolidated Q4 net up 67%, Domino’s sees muted growth

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Leading food services company Jubilant FoodWorks on Wednesday reported a consolidated net profit of ₹82.4 crore in the March quarter, up 67.1 per cent, over ₹49.3 crore in the corresponding quarter in the previous fiscal. Domino’s India posted a muted like-for-like (LFL) growth of 0.2 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) in Q4. The company said it was impacted due to factors like sequential timing of festivals and school examinations.

It added that dine-in and takeaway growth was relatively softer during the quarter, impacting overall LFL growth. “Our confidence in sustaining 5-7 per cent medium-term LFL growth for Domino’s India is

All is well (in ₹ crore)			
	Q4FY25	Q4FY26	Change (%)
Consolidated net profit	49.3	82.4	67.1
Consolidated revenue from operations	2,095.0	2,499.5	19.3

anchored in the strength of our fundamentals. Q1 FY27 LFL growth is likely to be higher than that of Q4 FY26,” it added. The company, which operates brands like Domino’s and Popeyes, posted consolidated revenue from operations of ₹2,499.5 crore, up 19.3 per cent over the year-ago period.

LPG SUPPLY

On the impact of challenges in commercial LPG availability due to the West Asia crisis, the company said, “During March, select markets experienced temporary LPG supply constraints,

which had a limited and localised impact on our operations. Overall, this translated into 30-40 basis points impact on Q4 like-for-like growth of Domino’s India.”

“Since then, we have progressively reduced our dependence on LPG, diversified vendor sourcing to further de-risk supply, and benefited from improved availability following the Government of India’s interventions. In Q1 FY27, LPG supply has largely normalised, and business operations have returned to pre-disruption levels,” the company said.

EXPENSES RISE

The company informed that total expenses in Q4 were higher at ₹32,355.72 crore as compared to ₹30,028.22 crore in the same period a year ago.

For FY26, the company reported consolidated net profit of ₹4,085.55 crore, a decline of 1.4 per cent y-o-y as against ₹4,145.7 crore in FY25, SAMIL said. However, consolidated total revenue from operations stood at ₹1,26,103.67 crore in FY26 as compared to ₹1,13,662.57 crore in FY25.

Meanwhile, the Board has recommended a final dividend of 25 paise per equity share of face value of ₹1 each, it added.

The improvement in the leverage ratio and a strong booked business of \$96 billion reinforces, the group’s commitment to sustainable value creation.

Shares of SAMIL closed at ₹132.30 apiece on the BSE on Wednesday, up 0.65 per cent from the previous close.

Amid W. Asia concerns, Commerce Dept maps import substitution, export push

THINK-TANK. Industry asked to suggest measures as rising oil prices threaten to widen current account deficit

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Amid the escalating crisis in West Asia, a weakening rupee and concerns over a widening current account deficit (CAD), the Commerce Department is carrying out a trade analysis to identify ways to curb imports, boost domestic manufacturing in sectors with large trade deficits and step up exports where India enjoys a trade surplus.

The department has reached out to export promotion councils and industry bodies with product-wise lists under four categories: High trade deficit, high import-negligible export, high trade surplus and high export-negligible import. It is seeking suggestions on measures to reduce import dependence, strengthen do-



GO LOCAL. Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal recently urged industry to support domestic supply chains **ANI**

mestic production and expand exports.

“The government wants to spare no effort in lowering imports, wherever possible, in order to conserve foreign exchange. The merchandise trade deficit has been widening and higher global crude oil prices are expected to add further strain. The Commerce Department hopes to come up with suggestions on import substitution and ex-

port promotion with the help of industry,” a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

RISEING OIL PRICES
The exercise assumes significance as Brent crude prices have risen sharply amid fears of supply disruptions in West Asia. India imports more than 85 per cent of its crude oil requirement, making elevated energy prices a major

risk for the trade balance, inflation and the rupee. The rupee has also remained under pressure due to volatility in global energy prices and capital flows.

In 2025-26, India’s merchandise trade deficit widened to a record \$333 billion, up over 17 per cent from the previous year. Economists have cautioned that a prolonged rise in crude prices could push the current account deficit well beyond comfort levels.

STRONG PITCH
Earlier this week, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal pitched strongly for import substitution and urged Indian industry to support domestic supply chains by sourcing locally. He specifically flagged heavy import dependence in segments of the capital goods sector and called upon industrial

clusters such as Rajkot, Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Batala and Pune to step up domestic manufacturing.

In its communication to export and industry bodies, the department said that for products with high trade deficits, suggestions should focus on reducing imports and strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities. For items where imports are high but exports negligible, the emphasis is on building production capacity and developing export competitiveness.

For products where India enjoys a high trade surplus, industry has been asked to suggest ways to further expand exports and access new markets. In categories where exports are high and imports negligible, suggestions have been sought on maintaining competitiveness and increasing value addition.

Thermal plants’ coal stock position stays comfortable even as the power demand scales new records

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Even as peak power demand has been breaking records this week, surpassing the 265 GW-mark on Wednesday, the country’s coal stocks remain comfortable.

Thermal power plants hold 51.98 million tonnes of reserves against a daily burn of roughly 3.10 million tonnes.

Of this, domestic coal-based plants with 203 GW installed capacity have stocks of 49.3 mt with a daily requirement of 2.9 mt. Imported coal-based plants (18.78 GW capacity) have stocks of

2.7 mt, with a daily requirement of 1.96 lakh tonnes.

Sources said that in FY27, thermal plants might consume up to 850 mt, up from 808 mt in FY26. The Power Ministry has made a demand of 906 mt coal for FY27 to the Coal Ministry, similar to the demand in FY26.

According to Coal Ministry data, thermal plants consumed a total of 852.5 mt of coal in FY26, which includes 808.8 mt of domestic supplies and 45.4 mt from imports.

India’s peak power demand during solar hours hit a record 260 GW on Tuesday, surpassing the 257 GW record on Monday.

Imported coal-based plants with 18.78 GW capacity have stocks of 2.7 mt, with a daily requirement of 1.96 lakh tonnes



However, the peak demand surpassed 265 GW on Wednesday, setting a new record.

“Today [Wednesday], at 15:45 hours, peak power demand [solar hours] of 265.44 GW was successfully met. This represents a new high in peak demand met, surpass-

try’s rising power demand. Coal accounted for almost 70 per cent of the generation in the last three days when peak demand scaled new records.

The national capital’s electricity demand also hit a record on Wednesday, surpassing the highs of Monday. Delhi’s peak power demand (daytime) touched 8,039 MW at 15:35 hours, the highest on record so far in 2026. Delhi discoms BSES and Tata Power DDL successfully met the demand.

While BSES discoms met the peak power demand of 3,665 MW and 1,753 MW in their respective areas, Tata Power DDL met the season’s peak demand of 2,249 MW.

US Secretary of State on 4-day India visit from May 23

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio will be on a four-day visit to India from May 23 to 26 to discuss stronger bilateral cooperation in trade, defence and energy security, as the West Asia crisis rages on. This will be Rubio’s first visit to India since assuming office.

The Secretary of State will be in New Delhi on Saturday and Sunday, and will also travel to Kolkata, Agra and Jaipur.

“The Secretary will discuss energy security, trade and defence cooperation during meetings with senior Indian officials,” US State Department Spokesperson Thomas Pigott noted in a statement.

The West Asia situation and Indo-Pacific security would also come up for discussion, sources said.

India is preparing to host the Quad Foreign Ministers meeting, reportedly on May 26. However, the US statement did not mention the meeting.

US officials said additional details of the India visit would be announced later.

INDIA-US BTA
The proposed India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) is also likely to be on the Secretary of State’s agenda, as Washington is keen to gain greater market access in the Indian market for its exporters of both industrial and agricultural goods, industry sources said.

New Delhi is watching the tariff situation in the US at the moment as it is still evolving following the US courts striking down certain additional tariffs, including reciprocal tariffs.

Rubio will travel from Sweden to India, where he is scheduled to attend the NATO Foreign Ministers Meeting, the statement shared.



DELHI DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Where Development Values Nature

DDA NAGRIK AWAAS YOJANA

Golden opportunity to own a house in Narela & Siraspur

Don't Miss Out
LAST DATE
31.05.2026

Encouraging response
EWS Flats
Totally Sold Out



25% DISCOUNT

Limited HIG & MIG Flats Available LIG Flats Also on Offer

FIRST COME, FIRST SERVE BASIS

HIG FLATS
STARTING PRICE: ₹ 95.88 Lakh
Starting Size Approx.: 160.25 Sq. Mtr.

MIG FLATS
STARTING PRICE: ₹ 67.03 Lakh
Starting Size Approx.: 114.05 Sq. Mtr.

LIG FLATS
STARTING PRICE: ₹ 11.51 Lakh
Starting Size Approx.: 35.76 Sq. Mtr.



Newly constructed flats with spacious balconies and ample parking



Located close to GT Karnal Road and UER-II



School, hospital, universities and local market nearby



Narela to become educational hub, metro connectivity soon



Siraspur near Samaypur Badli Metro Station

READY TO MOVE IN FREEHOLD SCHEME COMPLETELY ONLINE SAMPLE FLATS AVAILABLE

For assistance call at: 1800110332
For Booking & Registration, please visit: www.dda.gov.in or <https://eservices.dda.org.in>

Follow us on:  [ddaofficial](#)  [official_dda](#)  [official_dda_](#)

Core sector grew 1.7% in April, led by cement, steel and power

Asian News International
New Delhi

India’s eight core infrastructure sectors grew 1.7 per cent in April, with higher output in cement, steel and electricity partially offsetting declines in coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products and fertilizers, according to official data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

Among the sectors, coal production declined 8.7 per cent in April compared to the same month last year. Crude oil production fell 3.9 per cent, while natural gas output declined 4.3 per cent year-on-year. Petroleum refinery products output slipped 0.5 per cent, while fertilizer production contracted 8.6 per cent during the month.

On the positive side, steel production rose 6.2 per cent in April, cement output increased 9.4 per cent and electricity generation grew 4.1 per cent year-on-year. The Ministry said the eight core industries together account for 40.27 per cent of the weight of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), making them a key indicator of industrial activity in the country.

“The final growth rate of Index of Eight Core Industries for March 2026 was observed at 1.2 per cent,” the Ministry said.

India’s April crude oil imports down on lower Russian purchases by RIL, Nayara

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Overall crude oil imports declined on a monthly basis in April as Reliance Industries (RIL) and Nayara Energy limited their Russian purchases after the world’s third-largest consumer bought record volumes from Moscow a month earlier. According to the Finland-based Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), India was the second-largest buyer of Russian fossil fuels in April, importing a total of €5 billion (around \$5.82 billion) of hydrocarbons.

Crude oil constituted 90 per cent of India’s purchases, totalling €4.5 billion (\$5.24 billion). Coal (\$346 million) and oil products (\$243 million) made up the rest. “India’s total crude import volumes recorded a 3.7 per cent reduction in April. This is partially explained by a 19.4 per cent month-on-month (m-o-m) decrease in Russian imports,” CREA said.

There was a substantial change in unloading at refineries, with Vadinar and Jamnagar refineries’ Russian imports decreasing by almost 92 per cent and 38 per cent respectively, while the State-owned Indian Oil Vadinar refinery’s imports increased 87 per cent. The decline in Russian crude imports at the Vadinar refinery was driven by main-

tenance-related shutdowns beginning on April 9, as the refinery runs exclusively on Russian feedstock.

New Mangalore and Visakhapatnam refineries (MRPL) stopped Russian imports at the end of November 2025, but purchases resumed in March 2026 and continued into April, with Visakhapatnam’s Russian imports increasing 149 per cent m-o-m.

BIG SHIFT
In contrast, India’s imports of Russian crude oil doubled m-o-m in March 2026, even as cumulative crude imports recorded a 4 per cent reduction that month. The biggest shift was in State-owned refineries’ imports from Russia, which saw a massive 148 per cent increase in March 2026, presumably due to Russian barrels being more available in the spot market, which serve as their primary source of imports, CREA explained.

On Russian crude oil price dynamics during April 2026, CREA said the average price of Russia’s Urals crude rose further, up 19 per cent m-o-m to \$112.3 per barrel, remaining more than double the updated EU and UK price cap of \$44.1 per barrel, which took effect on February 1, 2026.

“In April, the price discount of Urals-grade crude oil relative to the global benchmark Brent plummeted,” CREA said.

LMW LIMITED (formerly Lakshmi Machine Works Limited) Registered Office : SRK Vidyalaya Post, Perianaickenpalayam, Coimbatore - 641 020, Tamil Nadu, India. Phone : +91 422 7192255; Website : www.lmwglobal.com; Email : secretaria@lmw.co.in CIN: L29269TZ1962PLC000463					
Statement of Standalone Audited Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31st March 2026 (₹ in Crores except Earnings Per Share)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.12.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total income from operations	889.37	794.92	822.47	3,221.40
2	Net Profit before Tax (before exceptional items)	71.80	56.30	62.67	221.06
3	Net Profit before Tax (after exceptional items)	71.41	44.80	62.67	207.88
4	Net Profit after tax (after exceptional items)	54.37	29.94	49.12	153.92
5	Total Comprehensive Income [Comprising Profit (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(8.20)	47.82	87.57	130.86
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face value of ₹10/- per share)	10.68	10.68	10.68	10.68
7	Reserves Excluding Revaluation Reserves as per Balance Sheet of previous accounting Year				2,959.96
8	Earnings Per Share (after extraordinary items) (Face Value of ₹10/- each) (Not annualised)				
	a. Basic	50.89	28.03	45.98	144.08
	b. Diluted	50.89	28.03	45.98	144.08
Statement of Consolidated Audited Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31st March 2026 (₹ in Crores except Earnings Per Share)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.12.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total income from operations	971.81	787.90	836.23	3,353.36
2	Net Profit before Tax (before exceptional items)	78.24	41.02	61.35	194.99
3	Net Profit before Tax (after exceptional items)	77.85	29.52	61.35	181.81
4	Net Profit after tax (after exceptional items)	63.69	14.66	47.82	130.73
5	Total Comprehensive Income [Comprising Profit (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	1.12	32.54	86.27	107.67
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face value of ₹10/- per share)	10.68	10.68	10.68	10.68
7	Reserves Excluding Revaluation Reserves as per Balance Sheet of previous accounting Year				2,855.84
8	Earnings Per Share (after extraordinary items) (Face Value of ₹10/- each) (Not annualised)				
	a. Basic	59.62	13.72	44.76	122.37
	b. Diluted	59.62	13.72	44.76	122.37
Notes:					
1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the above results is available on the Stock Exchange websites, namely www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website www.lmwglobal.com .					
2. The above results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on 20 th May 2026. The Statutory auditors have expressed an unqualified audit opinion.					
3. Effective from 21 st November 2025, the Government of India has consolidated multiple existing labour laws into a unified framework comprising four Labour codes collectively referred to as 'New Labour Codes'. Under IndAS 19 and as per the guidance issued by the ICAI, changes to employee benefit plans arising from legislative amendment constitute a plan amendment, requiring recognition of past service cost immediately in the statement of profit and loss. The New Labour Codes has resulted in estimated one time increase in provision for employee benefits of ₹11.50 crores as per actuarial valuation report and considering the materiality and non-recurring nature of this impact, the Company has presented such incremental impact as 'Statutory impact of new Labour Codes' under 'Exceptional items' in the statement of profit and loss for the year ended 31 st March 2026.					
4. The consolidated financial results for the quarter and year ended 31 st March 2026 includes financial results of wholly owned subsidiary companies: 1) LMW Holding Limited, UAE and 2) LMW Aerospace Industries Limited, India and also includes financial results of step down subsidiaries such as LMW Textile Machinery (Suzhou) Co. Ltd, China and LMW Global FZE, UAE.					
5. Events after reporting period: The Board has recommended a final dividend of 350% (₹ 35 per share of the face value of ₹ 10 each) for the financial year 2025-26 subject to the approval of the Shareholders in the ensuing Annual General Meeting.					
6. The figures for the last quarter are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of the full financial year and the published year-to-date figures up to the third quarter of the current financial year.					
7. Figures for the previous periods have been regrouped / rearranged wherever necessary.					
Coimbatore 20 th May 2026		 Scan this QR code to view the above Result in detail For LMW Limited Chairman and Managing Director			





A CH-CE

TECH DIGEST.

Meta introduces Incognito Chat

Meta has launched Incognito Chat with Meta AI, a feature that enables private conversations with its artificial intelligence



system. The service is built on Meta's Private Processing technology, which allows users to interact with Meta AI in a protected environment. Messages are not saved and disappear by default, creating temporary exchanges that remain inaccessible to Meta or others. Meta said Incognito Chat is intended for users who want to discuss personal, financial, health or work-related topics without records being kept. Meta also announced plans for Side Chat with Meta AI, a tool that will provide contextual assistance within ongoing conversations. Incognito Chat will roll out on WhatsApp and the Meta AI app in the coming months.

Samsung launches One UI 9 beta

Samsung has opened the One UI 9 beta programme, beginning with the Galaxy S26 series. The software is built on Android 17



and introduces updates across creative tools, customisation, accessibility and security. Samsung Notes now includes new pen styles and decorative tape

options, while the Contacts app links directly to Creative Studio for profile card creation. The Quick Panel has been redesigned, allowing independent adjustment of brightness, sound and media controls. Accessibility features include adjustable Mouse Key speed, a combined TalkBack package and a new Text Spotlight function that enlarges selected text in a floating window. Security has been strengthened with warnings and automatic blocking of high-risk apps, along with recommendations for removal. The full release of One UI 9 will arrive later this year with upcoming Galaxy flagship devices. The beta programme is available to Galaxy S26 users in select markets, including Germany, India, Korea, Poland, the UK and the US, through the Samsung Members app.

OPPO to launch Find X9s, Find X9 Ultra in India

OPPO will introduce the Find X9s and Find X9 Ultra in India on May 21, expanding the Find X9 series. The Find X9 Ultra features a 50 MP



telephoto system with 10x optical zoom, built on a quintuple prism periscope design that folds the optical path into a compact module. The device also includes a 200 MP main camera, a 200 MP 3x telephoto camera, and Hasselblad's imaging system. Video support extends to 8K at 30 fps and 4K at 120 fps, with options for O-Log2 recording and ACES colour workflows. It runs on Qualcomm's Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5 platform and uses OPPO's Trinity Engine with a new cooling system and a 7050mAh silicon-carbon battery. The Find X9s carries a triple 50 MP Hasselblad camera setup in a slimmer 7.99 mm design. It supports dual-video capture, 4K 60 fps Dolby Vision recording, and AI-powered features through ColorOS 16. Both phones integrate OPPO's Hasselblad Master Camera System and the LUMO Image Engine, which handle optics, sensor control, colour science and image processing. The series is positioned to support extended photography and video sessions with dedicated cooling and large-capacity batteries.

AI focus at Google I/O conference

Alphabet CEO Sundar Pichai opened Google's annual developer conference in Mountain View, California, highlighting



advances in artificial intelligence (AI). It is the company's first I/O since last winter's update to its Gemini AI model. Google has been embedding generative AI into its search engine

and linking Gemini to data across Chrome, Gmail and YouTube. Google's latest family of models, Gemini 3.5, rolled out on Tuesday to billions of global users beginning with Gemini 3.5 Flash. The Flash model is focused on speed, and Google says 3.5 Flash is its strongest agentic and coding model yet, but it's also about four times faster than some competitors. This model is now the default for the Gemini app and "AI mode" on Google search. Google also announced a new model, Gemini Omni, which will enable users to create high-quality video by making a query with any input, be it text, images, videos and audio. Also announced was Gemini Spark powered by Gemini 3.5. It will be able to complete mundane tasks like sorting through meeting notes, emails and chats, which will be converted into a document with the biggest takeaways and to-dos.

A natural evolution

ONEPLUS PAD 4. More power, extra brightness and improvements all around



STEAL DEAL. You get a premium Android tablet experience with a large display backed with an immersive 8-speaker audio set up and a battery that won't let you down ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN



Ashwin Rajagopalan

The OnePlus Pad 3 that debuted in 2025 was an ambitious upgrade — a clear statement that OnePlus intends to be a brand of choice in the premium tablet segment. It's why OnePlus' 2026 flagship tablet has its task cut out.

In a category where replacement cycles are longer than smartphones, the OnePlus Pad 4 aims to make a strong case for an Android flagship tablet, one that can switch from work to play effortlessly. It's a device that might allow you to leave your laptop behind during a one-day business trip or a short holiday. We think it does enough to justify that pitch.

DESIGN

Incredibly thin. That's the first thought that struck me as I unboxed the OnePlus Pad 4. It's a hair thinner than its predecessor; at 5.94 mm, this is one of the slimmest large-screen tablets out there. In terms of heft (the Pad 4 weighs 672 g), it's about the same as the OnePlus Pad 3 but there's one big difference — the battery under the hood. I didn't use the folio case to carry this tablet around, opting in-

stead to slip into a tablet sleeve during short work trips. It feels great in your hand; OnePlus has done a commendable job with the weight distribution.

We checked out the Dune Glow colourway that looks elegant with its dark grey hue combined with a bronze tint. The tablet also comes in a Sage Mist colour option. The Pad 4 is a magnet for fingerprints and smudges, that's only a problem if you're going to use your tablet without a keyboard cover or folio case. There's no fingerprint scanner which I believe is a must have at this price point; you have to lean on Face Unlock each time.

DISPLAY

On paper, the Pad 4 shares the same display specs as last year's Pad 3, except for one significant enhancement. You get the same 13.2-inch, 3.4K 'Tru Color Display' (3392 x 2400 pixels) with a 144 Hz refresh rate. It's not an OLED panel with those deep blacks though. The big, 'visible' change is the peak brightness that is now at 1000 nits. This enhances the overall viewing experience even outdoors, where the display does catch the occasional glare.

I watched *Sentimental Value* on MUBI during a domestic flight, and the minimal bezels and vibrant colours added to the cinematic appeal

of this critically acclaimed film. The OnePlus Pad 4 misses out on Widevine L1 certification; you don't get HD resolution on Netflix, which is a miss for a tablet at this price point. We do hope a future software update will address this. One of the key reasons consumers invest in premium tablets is for high quality video playback.

The 7:5 aspect ratio works well if productivity is your primary purchase driver for a tablet. I found that this ratio works better while scrolling through documents or editing spreadsheets on the fly but it doesn't work as well for 16:9 videos. Overall, this is still one of the best displays on an Android tablet.

PERFORMANCE

You'll struggle to find an Android tablet that rivals the OnePlus Pad 4 purely on performance creds. The device aced our Geekbench tests consistently clocking above 9700 (multi-core) in our benchmark tests. We tested the top-end, 12 GB/512 GB storage variant. The tab also comes in an 8 GB/256 GB option. I'd recommend paying the ₹5,000 premium for the top-end variant, especially if you're likely to multi-task frequently. At the heart of the Pad 4's firepower is the best of breed Qualcomm Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5 chipset. It also makes

the Pad 4 a future-proof investment, given that most of us hold on to our tablets for a few years. The spec sheet is only half of the performance story.

Oxygen OS 16 adds to the Pad 4's productivity pitch with effortless multi-tasking. I rarely toggle between more than two windows on a split screen, and the Pad 4 worked really well. The user interface is easy on the eye with minimal bloatware. You will need OnePlus' keyboard to truly unleash the potential of the Pad 4 as a serious productivity machine. OnePlus didn't ship the keyboard along with the Pad 4 for our review but we did check out the all-new One Stylus Pro that was fun to use. I noticed better gesture controls and more responsiveness than its predecessors, making this a great productivity accessory especially if you like to take notes or doodle at a meeting. You won't be able to use an older generation OnePlus stylus on the Pad 4 though.

You're unlikely to use a large tablet as your primary cam. The 13 MP rear cam and 5 MP front cam are good for the primary tasks we use tabs for — video calls and scanning documents.

BATTERY

The 13,380 mAh battery is one of

the most significant upgrades over the Pad 3 and delivers an impressive performance. I managed about 10-11 hours of video playback on full brightness, which should work for most users. There's an 80 W SUPERVOOC fast charger in the box that powers this device in about two hours.

VERDICT

The OnePlus Pad 4 comes with thoughtful enhancements over the Pad 3. It's certainly not an overhaul, you don't need to upgrade if you already own the Pad 3. There are some misses that include the lack of a 5G connectivity option, and yet this is a tablet that delivers great value for its price tag. You get a premium Android tablet experience with a large display backed by an immersive 8-speaker audio set up (4 woofers and 4 tweeters) and a battery that won't let you down.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹59,999 onwards
Pros: Design, battery life, user interface and multi-tasking abilities
Cons: No fingerprint scanner, no HD playback on Netflix, lack of a 5G option

Slinky slab with a premium vibe

SAMSUNG GALAXY A57 5G. Slim form, slimmer bezels and iterative upgrades

Ashwin Rajagopalan

One battle after another. That's what smartphone brands such as Samsung set out for each year. Samsung's A series launch typically follows the flagship S series debut each year and plays in the premium mid-range segment. This is one of the tougher battles for Samsung, where most consumers are sitting on the fence between flagship killers and the pricier S series flagships. The Samsung Galaxy A57 5G sits at the top of this year's A series line-up. Does it have the right mix to appeal to consumers willing to spend around ₹50,000-60,000 for a smartphone?

DESIGN

If there's one reason we'd recommend the A57, it's the form factor. Samsung has reduced the heft (over last year's Galaxy A56) by 20 g. That's a significant design achievement despite retaining the same battery capacity. The device is under 7 mm thin and weighs 179 g. Design teams work hard to create that wow moment when you first hold a smartphone at a retail store. This is a test the A57 passes in flying colours. It's not just the lightweight form factor, Samsung has nailed the ergonomics; this device feels great in your hand. It's a tad slippery and I'd recommend a back case if you have butter fingers. Samsung has improved the ingress protection over its predecessor with an IP68 rating.

DISPLAY

Display has traditionally been Samsung's core strength. While some of the display specs may not compare favourably on paper with some of the A57's rivals in this category, my real world experience suggests that this is a dependable binge watch screen complemented by punchy stereo speakers. While the bass may not be very deep, we like the overall soundstage. The display is now a



SNAP AWAY. Camera performance is solid across lighting scenarios, and portrait images are sharp with good edge detection ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN



Super AMOLED+ 6.7-inch screen (1080 x 2340 pixels) that hits a peak brightness of 1900 nits. The device comes with Widevine L1 support out-of-the-box that allows you to stream Netflix content in Full HD resolution. I watched two episodes of Season 2 of *Crooks* on Netflix; this display handled the contrasting colour palettes of the Austrian Alps and Bangkok's night spots effortlessly.

PERFORMANCE

This is a segment where brands such as OnePlus and iQOO ride on ultra-fast performance and monster batteries. The Samsung Galaxy A57 doesn't lean on raw power but aims to offer a balanced hardware and software performance that won't leave users gasping for breath. The device handled app switching and multi-tasking without breaking a sweat. At its heart is an Exynos 1680 processor. The device is available in 8 GB/256 GB and 12 GB/256 GB storage ver-



Vibrant colours captured on the primary lens



The rear camera shoots great images in optimal light

sions. The A57 managed a respectable score of above 4400 in our Geekbench (multi-core tests). It's certainly not in the top-tier in this segment but it's no slouch too.

Samsung's promise of six years of OS updates gives this device a clear edge. That's backed with the

AI smarts and the clutter-free One UI 8.5 that comes with a host of customisations.

The 5000 mAh battery life lasted a day in our tests but you might need to reach out for a charger slightly earlier if you're a heavy duty user or gamer. The device supports

45W charging that should power the device in about 75 minutes; it's certainly not the fastest in the segment. There's no charging brick in the box; I also believe that the lack of wireless charging at this price is a miss.

CAMERA

The rear camera set up includes a 50 MP primary lens that teams up with a 12 MP ultra-wide and a 5 MP macro lens. Camera performance is solid across lighting scenarios, portrait images are sharp with good edge detection. I find that I'm more likely to use a telephoto lens than a macro lens but that might boil down to personal preferences and use-case scenarios.

While the camera hardware hasn't changed from last year's A56, the device delivers a better performance thanks to software optimisations and a newer processor. I also found the AI-powered Edit Suggestions quite handy.

VERDICT

The Samsung Galaxy A57 comes with a significant price increase over last year's A56 that might also be driven by rising input costs the smartphone industry is grappling with. This is a segment with quite a few options, including last year's Samsung Galaxy S25 FE that scores over the A57 in a few areas such as wireless charging and a telephoto lens. There are also offerings from OnePlus, Nothing and Google that make a strong case in certain areas, such as display or battery performance. The Samsung Galaxy A57's appeal stems from its slinky form, premium build and a smooth overall performance backed by six years of OS updates.

● SNAPSHOTS

Price: ₹49,999 onwards
Pros: Design, form factor, 6 years of OS updates
Cons: Iterative upgrade, no telephoto camera, no wireless charging

Taking charge

EV charging stations should be vehicle-agnostic

In a recent development, Heavy Industries Minister HD Kumaraswamy cleared proposals for installing over 1,200 EV charging stations in Karnataka under the PM E-DRIVE, the tenure of which has recently been extended by two years. The PM E-DRIVE scheme, which initially ran for about a year and a half till March 2026, had aimed to set up 22,100 fast chargers for 4Ws, 1,800 for buses and 48,400 for e-2Ws and e-3Ws. The Centre recently said that there were 29,000 charging stations in the country — which suggests the need for expansion.

The current crude oil crisis underscores the importance of this push. EV demand hinges on availability of charging facilities and batteries for short and long distance travel. A couple of issues here need to be taken into consideration: compatibility between charging facilities, batteries and EVs; and the need to ensure that private charging facilities run by EV majors do not privilege their products over the rest. Most large OEMs have converged on the CCS-2 standard, the global norm for EV charging. Yet, digital fragmentation persists as some private operators mandate proprietary apps and pre-funded wallets to lock in loyalty — an inconvenience to consumers. Conversely, the two-wheeler industry is cleaved between two dominant, non-interoperable physical charging standards — the Type 6 and Type 7. Even if a vehicle happens to be physically compatible with a station's hardware, lacking the corresponding app negates the impact. In this context, an app-based approach to discovering charging stations, booking slots and paying for charging your vehicles across the public sector OMC network is a useful step forward. However, standardising the physical layer — the interface where the charging gun couples with the vehicle — remains a critical need.

Last year, the Centre mandated Type C chargers for new mobile phones sold, to curb electronic waste. Motorists pulling in for liquid fuel can use any petrol pump. EVs should likewise be agnostic to the charging stations. The retail user has so far tolerated inconveniences by charging overnight at home. For EVs to take off, charging stations available within a three-km radius inside cities is the way to go. Notably, public sector oil marketing companies have about one lakh outlets. They have created 11,000 charging stations, but there is scope to improve on this tally. This is crucial for EV adoption.

Globally, a 5 per cent EV market share marks an inflection point for exponential EV adoption. In India, passenger EV sales have breached 5 per cent in recent months; two-wheelers are nudging 6.5 per cent. To ensure that EVs remain in vogue even in the event of crude prices softening, the infrastructure push should be sustained. To be sure, charging infrastructure for long distance travel has improved. With rapid DC fast-charging, a mere 15-minute top-up can elevate a battery from 30 per cent to 80 per cent. In addition, solar-powered charging stations will drive home the energy advantage.

POCKET
RAVIKANTH



PRITAM BANERJEE

For the first half of the 20th century, the banks of the Hooghly River served as one of major industrial heartlands of Asia. Stretching nearly 100 km, this vibrant corridor was a metallurgical and engineering powerhouse that provided the inspiration for Japan's burgeoning industries.

Today, that legacy is a distant memory. A region that once defined economies of scale and sophistication in Asian manufacturing now accounts for less than 6 per cent of India's metallurgical output. Decades of industrial decline, rooted in the anti-industry political culture of Bengal starting in the 1970s, and exacerbated by five decades of misgovernance by the Left and Trinamool governments, have led to widespread factory closures and capital flight.

Despite this stagnation, the region retains an immense, untapped potential for a renaissance. To realise this, the West Bengal government must implement a dedicated package specifically tailored to the Greater Kolkata region, focusing on its comparative advantages in metallurgy and the burgeoning sector of Global Capability Centres (GCCs). Here are some ideas how.

METALLURGY, A GLOBAL HUB
The Greater Kolkata region still hosts a specialised ecosystem of approximately 3,000 registered metallurgical units, including a core of 320-500 foundries. This MSME-driven landscape possesses a niche expertise that can return Bengal to the centre of the global supply chain for advanced industrial materials and metalworking.

However, this cannot be achieved through cosmetic efforts involving minor subsidies or development of small-scale industrial parks that characterized the approach of previous state governments.

We must "dream big", with ambitious, seemingly outlandish targets. The goal should be achieving an industrial output exceeding \$50 billion and exports of \$25 billion within a decade, while creating one million direct and ancillary jobs. This is a realistic goal if we leverage the region's proximity to the mineral-rich belts of Odisha, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh.

Furthermore, the State should collaborate with the Centre to develop a customised PLI (Production Linked Incentive) scheme for metalworking, metallurgy and advanced materials industries going beyond the existing PLI for specialty steel, which specifically designed to allow small and



Industrial vision for the Greater Kolkata Region

ECONOMIC AGENDA. The existing metallurgical units can be turned into a global hub through a PLI scheme, brownfield expansion, and tapping port potential

medium-sized industries to benefit from.

BROWNFIELD DEVELOPMENT
The cornerstone of this revival must be brownfield development. Rather than relying solely on greenfield projects that face significant land acquisition hurdles, the focus should shift to revitalising "sick units" or those under litigation through a specialised Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) scheme. Here are the advantages of brownfield retrofitting.

Reduced lead times: Setting up in a brownfield zone can help units becoming operational within 6 to 12 months, compared to the 24 to 48 months required for greenfield clearances and construction.

Capex efficiency: Retrofitting typically reduces capital expenditure by 25-30 per cent.

Policy alignment: The Centre's Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana (BHAVYA) scheme explicitly supports

Rather than relying solely on greenfield projects, the focus should shift to revitalising "sick units" or those under litigation through a specialised Special Purpose Vehicle scheme

infrastructure modernisation for brownfield projects, serving as a significant force multiplier complementing state government resources to support Kolkata's revival.

PORT POWER
The Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port can be a primary catalyst for this industrial transformation. As Kolkata's largest landholder, the port authority controls approximately 11,000 acres — a land bank that offers significantly cheaper real estate than competitor hubs like Mumbai, Pune, or Chennai.

Greenfield potential: Lands near the Haldia dock system are uniquely suited for large-scale manufacturing and attracting Foreign Direct Investment (FDI).

The GCC revolution: Land parcels within 5-8 km of Kolkata's central business district are ideal for commercial GCC facilities. While the initial IT revolution bypassed the city, Kolkata's high-skilled manpower and lower operating costs make it the logical "next stop" for India's services export revolution.

Self-sustaining finance: By utilising SPVs, revenues from these lands can be reinvested into commercial assets that help finance port operations and industrial development of port held lands over the longer-run.

OVERCOMING OBSTACLES
The primary barrier to replicating a

London or Hamburg Docklands style revitalisation is a lack of political will to confront the "dockland mafia". Illegal occupations and the influence of political strongmen have deterred legitimate investment for decades. The port has failed to reach its potential because previous State administrations refused to support federal initiatives.

A comprehensive, courageous plan for urban and industrial revival would resonate with a middle class desperate for economic opportunity.

By aligning the port's development with a clear industrial roadmap, the government can replace a culture of litigation and stagnation with one of growth and entrepreneurship.

Renaming the port after Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee was a symbolic beginning. The true tribute to his legacy lies in reclaiming the economic pride of the city he defended. Transforming the Kolkata corridor into a global economic hub for advanced metallurgy and metalworking should be treated as Bengal's strategic industrial imperative.

Bengal under the new BJP led government must move beyond "small potatoes" thinking and implement a large-scale 'Kolkata region' industrial plan that restores this region to its rightful place among the world's great economic clusters.

The writer is Head, Centre for WTO Studies, Indian Institute of Foreign Trade (IIFT). Views expressed are personal

Why credit guarantees don't help a range of MSMEs

Bankers are hard-wired into overlooking enterprises that are too large for MUDRA, and yet unfamiliar with banking systems

Srinivas Ramanujam
Meera Siva

In March, the government launched CGSMFI-2.0 — a ₹20,000-crore credit guarantee scheme for microfinance institutions. The sector was in genuine distress: bank lending had contracted 8.5 per cent in the first half of FY2026, credit costs had surged to 15.5 per cent, and smaller MFIs were being frozen out.

The scheme was necessary but not sufficient.

This pattern, repeated across sectors, reveals a structural problem. When banks are offered a sovereign guarantee, they do not suddenly lend to the most excluded. Credit flows to larger, better-rated institutions which are already closest to being fundable. A guarantee does not change a lender's read of the borrower but only changes the cost of being wrong. And if the lender cannot read the borrower at all, the guarantee changes nothing.

LOST MSME DECADE
Similar dynamics have been at play in MSME lending at a larger scale. The MSME credit gap stands at ₹20-25 lakh crore and has not materially shifted in a decade, despite successive guarantee schemes starting with CGTMSE, established in 2000.

After a decade of voluntary participation and modest uptake, RBI made collateral-free lending mandatory for MSE loans up to ₹10 lakh in 2010. In the same breath, it urged that compliance be made a branch staff performance criterion — an early signal the mandate was already being ignored. Industry bodies later documented banks nudging borrowers to waive their CGTMSE cover so loans could be processed with collateral instead.

In February, the RBI raised that ceiling to ₹20 lakh. Inflation-indexing a broken compass does not show you the true North.

The aggregate evidence is damning. Only 14 per cent of MSMEs access formal credit; nearly 80 per cent remain self-financed or rely on moneylenders. CGTMSE's data show 93 per cent of its guarantees are for loans below ₹10 lakh — the segment banks were already mandated to serve. The enterprises that genuinely stall — too large for MUDRA, too unfamiliar for commercial banks, sitting between ₹20 lakh and ₹1 crore — remain unserved.

And the lender's reluctance cannot even be explained by default risk: gross NPAs in the MSE segment stood at under 4 per cent as of March 2024, down from over 9 per cent in 2022. Risk perception and risk reality are disconnected.



CREDIT. Helping the small player

BUILDING CREDITWORTHINESS
What would change this is designing the system such that making borrowers creditworthy becomes someone's explicit mandate and their measurable reward. The reason banks gravitate to better-rated borrowers, whether MFIs or MSMEs, is that weaker borrowers are simply unreadable: no financial records, no repayment history, no sector data. Guarantees cannot fix invisibility.

Three things are needed: guarantee coverage that actually reaches the missed borrowers (the smallest MFIs and the missing-middle MSMEs); technical assistance paired with those guarantees to build borrower capacity; generate data that shifts the lender's calculus from fear to evidence; and funded borrower financial literacy, so

they can present themselves effectively. Together, these build the track record that eventually makes the guarantee unnecessary — provided guarantee institutions, development finance bodies, and enterprise support organisations work in concert rather than in silos.

We have seen this work. An agri-tech enterprise serving smallholder farmers — the kind that commercial lenders routinely decline — received a guarantee-backed loan of ₹25 lakh paired with structured technical support. Within six months it graduated to a loan without a guarantee. Within four years of that first loan, it listed on the BSE SME Exchange. That listing represented over 50,000 smallholder farmers with higher incomes. It followed from the guarantee structure opening the door, technical assistance building the path, and an enterprise that learned to stand on its own.

The MFI guarantee scheme launched in March will provide necessary liquidity support to some institutions in the short term. The MSME amendments in February are steps in the right direction. But if the pattern holds, the credit gap will look much the same two years or even two decades from now.

Ramanujam is CEO, Villgro Innovation Foundation, and Siva is CEO, Inklude Impact Foundation. Both work on enterprise finance and innovation in India

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Redesigning MBA
This refers to the article 'Short-term biz vision' (May 20). It is rightly stressed that MBA education in India should not be a copy of what is taught in developed countries. The curriculum for MBA should maintain required balance in teaching production, finance and human resource management along with latest technology. Besides, MBA programmes should train both job seekers and job creators. For this the success story of start-ups and their failure as well

tells that learning entrepreneurship attributes is different from learning to run enterprises. As such MBA programmes could be run as two streams. Indian industry needs both.
YG Chouksey
Pune
Creating entrepreneurs
It refers to 'Short term biz vision'. Uday Kotak has hit the nail on its head. Tatas, Birlas, Hinduja's, Godrejs all of them have created solid businesses and empires which have stood the test of time. Today's start-ups need to ask

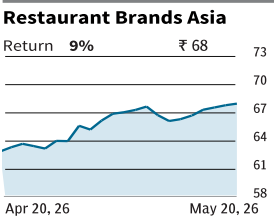
themselves how many of them see their companies doing sustainable business even after 2-3 decades. Chasing valuation should not be the sole objective of our start-ups.MBA curriculum also needs to be overhauled go under an overhaul. MBA colleges should produce real entrepreneurs who can create something innovative and sustainable. For that to happen the government must increase their focus and budgetary support on R&D.
Bai Govind
Noida

despite having fuel, to profit from the next increase. This erodes consumer trust and sparks unnecessary panic. Frequent minor revisions also blur transparency, making citizens feel cheated rather than informed. Instead of incremental tinkering, a more predictable and rational pricing mechanism is needed. Stability in fuel pricing reduces administrative hassles, ensures fairness and curbs political and social unrest.
O Prasada Rao
Hyderabad



QUICKLY.

CCI clears Lenexis-Burger King India operator deal



New Delhi: The Competition Commission of India on Wednesday approved the acquisition of a partial ownership in Restaurant Brands Asia Ltd, the operator of Burger King outlets in India, by a consortium led by Lenexis Foodworks Pvt Ltd. The proposed acquisition involves the buying of a certain stake in Restaurant Brands Asia through various steps, including equity subscriptions, warrant subscriptions, equity purchases and an open offer, the competition watchdog said. Apart from Lenexis Foodworks Pvt Ltd, the consortium includes Inspira Foodworks Pvt Ltd, Aayush Agrawal Trust , Inspira Agro Trading LLC and Aayush Madhusudan Agrawal.

Wealth Co Large & Mid Cap Fund NFO opens today

Chennai: The Wealth Company Mutual Fund, part of the Pantomath Group, has announced the launch of The Wealth Company Large & Mid Cap Fund, an open-ended equity scheme investing in both large cap and mid cap stocks. The new fund offer (NFO) opens on May 21 and closes on June 4. The scheme aims to provide long term capital appreciation by investing predominantly in equity and equity related securities of large cap and mid cap companies. Structured as an actively managed portfolio, the fund will maintain a minimum allocation of 35 per cent each to large cap and mid cap companies.

SEBI proposes easing third-party payment norms in mutual funds

MONEY ORDER. It suggests allowing salary deductions for MF investments, commission payouts for distributors

Our Bureau Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Wednesday proposed easing restrictions on third-party payments in mutual funds by permitting such transactions in select cases, including salary deductions by employers for employee investments and commission payouts to distributors in the form of MF units.

The regulator also proposed enabling investors to contribute or donate towards social causes through mutual fund schemes under a regulated framework.

Currently, MF investments must originate from an investor's own bank account and be routed through

RBI-authorized payment aggregators or SEBI-recognised clearing corporations. This was introduced to mitigate risks related to money laundering and ensure a complete audit trail.

However, SEBI said the MF industry had sought relaxation in certain genuine cases “such as payment of salaries by employers, payment of commissions by AMCs etc with adequate safeguards in place.”

PAYROLL INVESTMENTS Under the proposal, listed and EPFO-registered companies would be allowed to facilitate investments in mutual fund schemes on behalf of employees through payroll deductions. “This mechanism would allow AMCs to accept consolidated



COST EFFICIENCY. SEBI has also proposed permitting AMCs to pay trail commissions, or part thereof, to empanelled distributors in the form of MF units

payments for mutual fund investments through salary deduction,” the paper said. SEBI proposed that only employees opting for the arrangement would be covered, and they would be allowed to choose schemes for salary deductions.

SEBI also proposed per-

mitting asset management companies (AMCs) to pay trail commissions, or part thereof, to empanelled mutual fund distributors in the form of MF units. According to the consultation paper, the move would provide “a convenient, seamless and disciplined way of investing

in MF units for the MFD and encourages the MFDs to save and invest for the long term.”

Only distributors registered with AMFI and selling schemes of the concerned AMC would be eligible for the facility.

On social impact investing, the regulator proposed allowing investors to contribute a part of their subscription amount or scheme returns towards a social cause through mutual funds.

SEBI has proposed two options for implementing the donation framework – either through dedicated mutual fund schemes or by allowing all existing schemes to offer such a facility.

SEBI has sought public comments on the proposals till June 10.

Nifty erases gap-down, ends up as energy stocks lead recovery

Anupama Ghosh Mumbai

Equity benchmarks staged a comeback on Wednesday, pulling back from steep morning losses to end marginally in the green, as buying in energy, auto and realty stocks offset persistent pressure from a record-weak rupee and elevated crude oil prices.

“Markets recovered from intra-day lows, supported by selective buying in large-cap stocks across autos, financials, and oil & gas... recent fuel price hikes supported sentiment for OMCs and refiners,” said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments.

The BSE Sensex settled at 75,318.39, up 117.54 points, while the Nifty 50 closed at 23,659, gaining 41 points.

Both indices had opened sharply lower — the Nifty gapping down 161 points to 23,457 — before recovering

nearly 300 points from the session's low of 23,397 to close near the day's high.

SECTORAL SCENARIO Oil & Gas was the standout sector, rallying over 1.5 per cent, driven by IOC, BPCL and Reliance Industries. Investors reacted positively to domestic fuel price hikes and a partial cooling in Brent crude, which eased from above \$111-112 earlier in the week toward the \$105-106 range during the session.

Auto, realty and PSU banks also ended higher, while media, FMCG and IT remained under pressure. The Nifty Midcap 100 outperformed, rising 0.49 per cent, while the Smallcap 100 edged up 0.04 per cent. Market breadth was neutral, with the BSE advance-decline ratio at 1.07.

India VIX declined 1.26 per cent to 18.44, reflecting some easing in anxiety toward the close.

AB Capital to raise ₹4,000 cr through pref issue

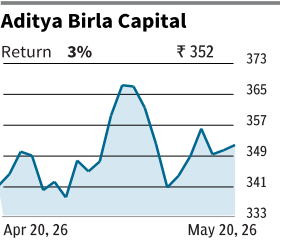
Our Bureau Mumbai

Aditya Birla Capital plans to raise ₹4,000 crore through a preferential issue. It will mop up ₹2,880 crore from its parent Grasim Industries, ₹200 crore from Suryaja Investment Pte, Singapore (an Aditya Birla Group entity) and ₹920 crore from International Finance Corporation.

The fund raise is aimed at strengthening the capital base and meeting the requirements for its next phase of growth.

The preferential issuance will be undertaken at the price of ₹356 a share.

GROWTH FUNDING The proceeds from the issu-



ance will be used to augment capital base, fund the lending business and other general corporate purposes.

Kumar Mangalam Birla, Chairman, Aditya Birla Group, said that as financial sector evolves, institutions with diversified platforms, strong governance and technology-led execution are increasingly shaping the growth trajectory.

“The company's breadth

across segments, combined with a long-term approach to building institutional capability, positions the group well as India's financial sector enters its next phase of expansion and sophistication,” he said.

Vishakha Mulye, MD & CEO, Aditya Birla Capital, said the capital infusion will enable the company to participate in the growth opportunities in India, deepen customer engagement and deliver digital-first solutions. About 57 per cent of the company's loan portfolio comprises business loans to SMEs, reflecting strong commitment to this segment, she said.

“We empower individuals and businesses with seamless credit access, digital cap-

abilities, and deep ecosystem solutions to drive sustainable, long-term growth,” she added.

JOB CREATION Sarvesh Suri, Regional Vice President, Asia and the Pacific, IFC, said that by leveraging ABCL's scale, over 150,000-strong MSME client base, and digital capabilities, the company aims to expand access to responsible financing for entrepreneurs and businesses in job-rich sectors — enabling them to invest, grow incomes, create more and better jobs and strengthen local economies.

The lending portfolio of ABCL across NBFC and Housing Finance grew at a 30 per cent CAGR to over ₹2 lakh crore.

HDFC Mutual reports cybersecurity threat

Our Bureau Mumbai

HDFC Asset Management Company, one of the largest mutual fund houses, has reported cybersecurity threat incidents.

“We hereby inform you about a cybersecurity incident that occurred at HDFC Asset Management Company on May 16, wherein we have received a communication from an anonymous source claiming access to certain portions of our IT infrastructure,” the fund house said.

The company promptly activated the necessary protocols for containment and incident response, and has engaged a specialist firm to

assess the potential impact, it said.

‘NO MATERIAL IMPACT’ While the detailed assessment is ongoing, based on the initial assessment, the incident is unlikely to affect the continuity of business and operations and there does not appear to be any material impact on the company's operations, it added.

Last April, Nippon Life India Asset Management (Nippon MF) experienced a major cybersecurity incident that temporarily disabled its digital platforms.

The attack hit the company's IT infrastructure, causing website and mobile app outages.

Srinivas L, Joint MD & Joint CEO, 63SATS Cyber-

tech, said AMCs and financial institutions managing public funds must move beyond traditional cybersecurity frameworks, particularly when they are handling massive public wealth and trust of millions of retail and institutional investors.

For an AMC, the risks include data exploitation such as misuse of Personally Identifiable Information, banking details, or proprietary trading algorithms besides threat to alter portfolio valuations or disrupt high-speed transaction pipelines, he said.

Even a contained incident with no material data loss can trigger immediate market volatility and shake investor confidence, as seen in short-term stock movements post disclosure.

SEBI's revised savings formula lifts India's FY25 savings ratio by 47 bps

Akshata Gorde Mumbai

A revised methodology adopted by the Securities and Exchange Board of India for calculating household savings through securities markets has increased India's gross savings-to-GDP ratio for FY25 to 34.94 per cent from 34.47 per cent estimated under the previous method.

Household savings through securities markets stood at ₹6.91 lakh crore in FY25 under the revised methodology, compared with ₹5.43 lakh crore under the earlier framework, according to a SEBI research paper prepared in consultation with the RBI and the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation.

The paper, authored by officials from the regulator's Department of Economic and Policy Analysis, said the earlier methodology relied

partly on estimates and did not fully capture investments through secondary markets, preferential allotments, private debt placements, REITs, InvITs and other market-linked instruments.

“Under the revised methodology, the household savings-to-GDP ratio for FY25 is 21.7 per cent compared to 21.23 per cent under the previous methodology. Similarly, net household financial savings improved to 7.10 per cent of GDP, up from the former estimate of 6.63 per cent,” the paper said.

REVISED FRAMEWORK The revised framework uses transaction-level data sourced from the stock exchanges, depositories and the Association of Mutual Funds in India to provide a more comprehensive estimate of household financial savings.

Earlier, 35 per cent of pub-

lic and rights equity issuances and 40 per cent of public corporate debt issuances were broadly treated as household savings. Secondary market investments and several newer instruments were excluded.

The paper said that rising retail participation in financial markets, especially after the pandemic, made a revision necessary. Households were net sellers of direct equity to the tune of ₹54,786 crore in FY25, and ₹69,329 crore the year before, even as they were record buyers of MFs. “This is maturation. The Indian retail investor is booking gains on direct stockholdings and outsourcing fresh allocation to professional vehicles,” said Jimeet Modi, Founder and CEO, SAMCO Group.

Of the ₹6.91 lakh crore households put into securities markets in FY25, roughly four-fifths flowed through the MFs.

SMR Jewels IPO opens on May 26 at ₹128-135 band

Our Bureau Ahmedabad

Ahmedabad-based SMR Jewels will launch its initial public offering (IPO) on the BSE-SME platform on May 26, targeting ₹67.23 crore.

The IPO comprises a fresh issue of up to ₹54 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of up to ₹13.23 crore. The price band has been fixed at ₹128-135 a share. The issue will close on May 29.

The company proposes to utilise the net proceeds towards capital expenditure for the construction of a jewellery studio, repayment and/or prepayment of certain borrowings and funding working capital needs.

TODAY'S PICK.

Shyam Metals & Energy (₹921.55): BUY

Gurumurthy K bl. research bureau

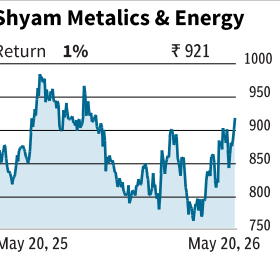
The short-term outlook is bullish for Shyam Metals & Energy.

The share price has been moving inside a bull channel since March this year. It is now moving up towards ₹960, the upper end of the channel.

We see high chances for the share price to breach ₹960. Such a break can take Shyam Metals & Energy share price up to ₹1,000 and even ₹1,040 in the coming months.

Key supports are at ₹890 and ₹870. Traders can buy Shyam Metals & Energy shares now at ₹921. Accumulate on dips at ₹905.

Keep the stop-loss at ₹865.



Trail the stop-loss up to ₹930 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹945.

Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹955, ₹980 and ₹995 when the price touches ₹970, ₹990 and ₹1,005 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹1,020.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	Wt(%)
Reliance Ind	1359.70	54.49	19.22	8.46
Hindalco	1085.50	11.74	15.17	1.45
Axis Bank	1249.80	7.19	14.63	3.30
Bajaj Auto	10462.50	6.22	27.65	1.07
M&M	3122.20	5.83	20.85	2.57
NTPC	392.45	3.15	15.33	1.71
Grasim Ind	2971.10	2.98	21.35	1.04
Bajaj Finserv	1772.00	2.79	14.42	0.94
Kotak Bank	383.20	2.01	19.76	2.60
State Bank	950.90	1.90	18.13	3.64
Infosys	4264.60	1.69	51.35	0.89
Adani Ports	1772.60	1.58	31.95	1.21
ONGC	298.30	1.52	8.34	1.07
Trent Ltd.	4099.90	1.47	84.67	0.84
Maruti Suzuki	13003.00	1.34	27.85	1.57
PowerGrid Corp	299.90	1.28	17.51	1.25
Wipro	197.12	1.22	15.58	0.52
Apollo Hosp	8078.50	1.18	62.26	0.77
Max Healthcare	1075.70	1.13	73.76	0.74
UltraTech Cement	11409.00	1.06	41.06	1.25
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	234.67	0.99	95.51	0.71
Coal India	458.70	0.87	9.10	0.96
Titel	4185.40	0.40	71.85	1.56
TCS	2327.40	0.07	17.03	2.19
Tata Motors PV	361.25	0.02	4434.49	0.70
Asian Paints	2598.60	-0.21	63.75	1.08
Bajaj Finance	923.10	-0.26	29.71	2.28
Tata ConsumerProduct	1208.70	-0.31	77.33	0.73
JSW Steel	1283.20	-0.41	12.30	1.11
Sun Pharma	1880.30	-0.46	41.19	1.83
Eicher Motors	6849.50	-0.99	35.07	0.87
Shriram Finance Ltd.	923.45	-1.19	21.67	1.19
HDFC Life	605.10	-1.24	68.27	0.60
Adani Enter	2704.80	-1.26	35.12	0.71
Cipla	1399.50	-1.26	29.27	0.73
TBIL Life	1864.20	-1.68	75.69	0.77
Dr Reddy's Lab	1321.90	-1.77	26.54	0.74
NestleIndia	1420.10	-1.77	78.26	0.94
HCL Tech	1169.80	-2.21	19.06	1.14
Infosys	1193.70	-2.45	16.42	3.86
U&I	3910.70	-2.64	28.38	4.23
Tech Mahindra	1459.00	-3.89	29.34	0.84
Tata Steel	207.01	-4.11	23.74	1.58
Hind Unilever	2209.30	-4.57	49.05	1.81
ICIICI Bank	1237.30	-5.46	15.29	8.15
Bharti Airtel	1904.90	-5.76	34.32	5.39
ITC	307.55	-5.78	18.61	2.73
Essential Ltd	240.34	-6.08	54.62	1.62
Bharat Elec	413.30	-7.54	50.67	1.36
HDFC Bank	759.50	-9.84	14.76	10.71

Nifty Next 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	Wt(%)
Siemens Energy India .	3459.60	73.93	94.06	1.25
Cg Power & Ind Sol	853.25	65.56	112.29	2.98
Commcast India	5399.50	55.48	50.74	2.23
Tvs Motor Cmp.	3361.90	52.04	50.12	2.21
Bpcl	293.75	41.76	5.18	2.42
Abb India	6605.00	40.87	88.58	1.41
Siemens	3696.40	36.30	83.03	1.33
Indian Oilcorp	138.04	32.06	5.29	2.10
Bajaj Holdings	10468.00	18.94	11.90	1.84
Hdfc Amc	2202.24	13.43	32.74	3.71
Indian Hotels Co.	659.60	16.98	41.78	2.36
Adani Energy Solutions .	1346.10	16.26	67.58	1.90
Zyduslisciences	1040.85	15.50	20.84	1.06
Bank Of Baroda	263.55	15.45	6.79	1.99
Canara Bank	127.66	14.37	6.48	1.75
Adani Power .	2202.24	13.43	32.74	3.71
Dif	583.30	10.68	32.71	1.52
Cholamandalamin&fin	1518.90	9.07	24.73	2.65
Punjab Natl Bank	102.22	8.95	6.36	1.43
Samvardhamothersinternatl	132.17	8.50	38.33	2.38
Solar Industries	18210.00	6.46	94.89	1.81
Bajaj Holdings	379.70	6.19	46.18	3.23
Hdfc Amc	2487.80	3.22	55.69	0.75
Indian Hotels Co.	1187.45	2.86	40.25	0.74
Cholamandalamin&fin	3909.30	1.73	12.53	1.47
Bank Consumer	1022.90	1.02	56.23	1.67
Reliance	159.90	0.22	6.25	1.25
Reliance	1455.60	-0.18	59.96	1.84
Cement	24420.00	-0.19	90.39	1.33
Siemens Railway Finance Corp	97.13	-0.51	18.81	0.50
Siemens	25.70	-0.25	19.35	0.50
Capital	300.60	-0.52	26.09	0.53
Zinc	630.45	-2.63	19.26	1.11
Beverages .	514.00	-3.09	54.17	2.86
Steel	1223.10	-3.35	37.12	1.84
Aeronautics	4326.50	-3.59	31.74	3.34
Life	155.64	-3.65	11.89	1.71
India	232.00	-4.41	53.62	1.82
Lab	6893.00	-6.32	73.89	5.77
Power	413.50	-7.79	25.82	2.82
Pharma	36830.00	-7.35	39.40	1.30
Pharma	429.20	-9.12	65.98	1.85
Finance	423.95	-9.25	42.1	2.54
Protect Devices .	888.00	-9.70	56.52	1.01
Specialty	1362.20	-13.82	113.0	1.86
Developers .	1284.60	-19.30	50.05	1.54
anta	334.75	-18.71	8.23	2.31
India	533.50	-23.95	50.74	2.56
Indirect	414.00	-29.28	24.65	1.56
Insurance	4144.20	-38.15	90.80	2.48

QUICKLY.

Greece’s Eurobank sets up India office

Mumbai: Greece’s Eurobank has set up a representative office in India in its maiden foray outside Europe to tap trade and investment opportunities. Eurobank has assets of around €110 billion and has operations in Cyprus, Bulgaria and Luxembourg. The office will be inaugurated by Cyprus President Nikos Christodoulides in Mumbai on Thursday. Its opening is significant in the context of India-EU FTA with Greece and Cyprus positioning themselves as investment gateways for Indian corporates. Eurobank, which has Fairfax has its largest shareholder, has begun offering cross border remittances for Indians in Greece via UPI. For now office will offer advisory service and financing options for trade and investments from its European branches. The bank is looking at high net worth individuals and family offices to set up presence in Cyprus, said Country Head and Chief Representative Officer Tridib Saha. OUR BUREAU

PM discusses trade, AI, energy and technology ties with Italian President

GROWING ENGAGEMENT. Modi stresses on the significance of India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor

Press Trust of India
Rome

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday called on Italian President Sergio Mattarella and held discussions on further expanding the bilateral partnership in areas such as trade, investment, technology, critical minerals, AI, space and nuclear energy. Modi, who arrived in Italy on Tuesday on the concluding leg of his five-nation tour, called on President Mattarella at Quirinale, the Presidential Palace in Rome. In a social media post, Modi said he discussed different aspects relating to the India-Italy friendship, including trade, investment and cultural linkages with Mattarella. “We talked about how our



COLLABORATION TALKS. Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Italian President Sergio Mattarella at the Quirinale Palace in Rome on Wednesday PTI

nations can collaborate in areas such as AI, critical minerals, space and nuclear energy,” Modi said. The two leaders noted the upward trajectory in India-Italy strategic partnership and expressed satisfaction at the ongoing cooperation in trade and investment, science and technology, research and innovation, defence and security, space, energy, artificial intelligence

and critical technologies, education, culture and people-to-people ties, the Ministry of External Affairs said in a statement. They also exchanged views on emerging technologies and Artificial intelligence, it said. The two leaders noted that the early signing of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement would impart new momentum to the partnership. They discussed the significance of the multimodal India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) for ensuring maritime security, digital connectivity and energy supplies. **ITALIAN INVESTMENTS** India and Italy have witnessed growing economic engagement in recent years, with bilateral trade reaching €14.25 billion in 2025, according to the Indian Embassy in Italy. India’s exports stood at €8.55 billion, while Italian exports to India were recorded at €5.70 billion in 2025, marking an increase of 9.42 per cent over 2024. The two countries have set a target of raising annual bilateral trade to €20 billion by 2029. Italy is India’s fourth-largest trading partner in the European Union and has identified India as one of the priority countries under its global trade strategy. Italy ranked 19th in foreign direct investment inflows into India between April 2000 and September 2025, with cumulative investments amounting to \$3.66 billion. Indian investments in Italy are estimated around €490 million.

Rupee slips 16 paise, hits lifetime low of 96.86 against dollar

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Declining for the ninth consecutive session, the rupee depreciated 16 paise to close at a fresh lifetime low of 96.86 against the US dollar on Wednesday as elevated global crude prices amid the West Asia crisis stoked inflation worries. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.89 against the US dollar, then lost further ground to touch a record low of 96.95. It went up to the day’s high of 96.65 before settling at a fresh all-time low of 96.86 against the greenback, registering a fall of 16 paise over its previous close. In the previous session, the rupee tumbled 50 paise to settle at 96.70 against the dollar.

“The Indian rupee hit fresh lows on a strong dollar and a surge in US treasury yields. US 30-year treasury yields rose to a two-decade high, while the 10-year yields rose to a 16-month high. “This led to inflation worries and sell-off in global markets, making the markets risk-averse,” said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Commodities Research at Mirae Asset Sharekhan. “We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on risk aversion in the global markets amid inflation worries. A strong dollar and rising US Treasury yields raised inflation concerns and trimmed rate cut expectations. USD/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹96.5 to ₹97.10,” he added. The rupee’s sharp decline has emerged as one of the biggest economic warning signs for policymakers, investors and businesses. Once



The rupee’s decline has emerged as one of the biggest economic warnings for policymakers

considered among Asia’s more stable currencies, the rupee has now become one of the worst-performing emerging market currencies this year, pressured by a toxic mix of expensive oil, capital outflows, widening trade deficits and a surging US dollar. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.42, higher by 0.09 per cent. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading down 2.77 per cent at \$109.95 per barrel in futures trade. The US Senate advanced legislation on Tuesday that seeks to force President Donald Trump to withdraw from the Iran war, as a growing number of Republicans defied President Donald Trump’s wishes. On the domestic equity market front, Sensex rose by 117.54 points to settle at 75,318.39, and Nifty was up 41 points to 23,659. Foreign Institutional Investors offloaded equities worth ₹1,597.35 crore on a net basis on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

PFC’s ₹26,000-cr, 30-year loan to set stage for nuclear financing

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

In a bid to establish a sector-specific long-term financing mechanism for setting up nuclear power plants (NPPs), stakeholders, including the Central Electricity Authority (CEA) and the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE), have suggested a 30-year tenure loan facility. Nuclear projects present a distinctive financing challenge with high capital outlay. For instance, ₹30 crore per megawatt (MW) and above construction cost, extended gestation periods of 7-10 years, RBI’s revised project finance norms re-

quiring 51 per cent or more of debt repayment from project cash flows, bankable PPAs, and a 10 per cent cap on cost overrun funding with asset downgrade triggers. These structural constraints necessitate a bespoke financing architecture. These findings emerged from a workshop, organised by the Power Ministry and CEA, which included senior officials from the DAE, NTPC, Nuclear Power Corporation of India (NPCIL), financial institutions, industry stakeholders, private sector among others. **FIRST OF ITS KIND** The workshop identified long-tenure debt of 30 years

as essential for tariff competitiveness. For instance, it said the ₹26,000 crore 30-year loan sanctioned to NPCIL by PFC is the first such long-tenure nuclear loan in India, thereby establishing a benchmark transaction for the sector. This recommended multi-layered financing approach combines government infrastructure bonds, Development Finance Institution lending at concessional rates, back-loaded repayment structures aligned with tariff profiles, potential sovereign credit support, and debt-equity ratios potentially reaching 85:15 for strong balance sheet borrowers.



The representatives at the workshop also noted the interest from multilateral financiers including the BRICS New Development Bank in supporting pre-feasibility and detailed project studies for early-stage de-risking. During the workshop, a participant inquired about

the indicative tariff calculations assuming a 30-year loan tenure, which is a product not presently available in the Indian market as a standard offering. The government officials confirmed that the tariff calculations do assume a 30-year tenure, and it was clarified that while such tenures are not directly available through standard bank products, refinancing makes 30 years achievable in practice. PFC’s recent balance sheet loan to NPCIL at above 30-year tenure was cited as evidence by the government officials emphasising that the product is achievable, and it was noted that as the

sector matures and lenders become familiar with nuclear project risk, 30-year project finance loans will follow, as has been the experience with hydro and transmission. The government also clarified that nuclear tariffs under the SHANTI Act (Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India Act) are neither Section 62 nor Section 63. It is a distinct cost-of-service model governed by DAE, and the Electricity Act norms do not apply. While Section 62 of the Electricity Act deals with determining tariffs, Section 63 deals with transparent bidding to discover tariffs.

Where Maharashtra’s Next Growth Story Takes Shape

Today, the state is entering a new era of redevelopment and infrastructure transformation. From new growth corridors and maritime ambitions to the rise of the extended MMR, the future of Maharashtra is being redesigned in real time.

Friday, May 22, 2026 | 10:00 am Onwards
President, Mumbai - IHCL SeleQtions, Mumbai

Key Dignitaries



Eknath Shinde
Deputy Chief Minister, Maharashtra



Dr Shrikant Shinde
Member of Parliament



Girish Mahajan
Cabinet Minister for Water Resources (Vidarbha, Tapi & Konkan), Kumbh Mela, & Disaster Management



Nitesh Rane
Minister for Fisheries & Ports Development



Ashish Shelar
Guardian Minister, Mumbai (Suburbs)



Ashwini Bhide, IAS
Municipal Commissioner, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC)



Presents



Maharashtra Infrastructure Conclave

Featured Sessions

Mumbai to Surjagad: Expressway to Prosperity
Address by **Eknath Shinde**, Deputy Chief Minister, Maharashtra

Navigating The Financial Capital
Ashwini Bhide, BMC Commissioner in conversation with **Vinaya Vilas Deshpande**, Chief of Bureau, The Hindu

Mumbai and Beyond: The Plan for an Expanding Metropolis
Dr Shrikant Shinde, Member of Parliament
Ashish Shelar, Guardian Minister, Mumbai (Suburbs)
Dr Sanjay Mukherjee, IAS, Metropolitan Commissioner, Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA)
Dr Mahendra Kalyankar, IAS, Chief Executive Officer, DRP/SRA
Moderated by **Pankaj Joshi**, Principal Director of Urban Centre, Mumbai

Kumbh: The Spiritual Boost for a Regional Economy
Girish Mahajan, Cabinet Minister for Kumbh Mela
Manisha Khatri, Municipal Commissioner, Nashik Municipal Corporation
Shekhar Singh, Commissioner, Nashik Kumbh Mela
Lubaina Rangwala, Program Head, Urban Development, WRI India
Moderated by **Lalatendu Mishra**, Senior Deputy Editor, The Hindu

To know more, Visit: newsth.live/THINFC2026PA

Associate Partners



Telecast Partner



To register, visit:
newsth.live/THINFC2026PA
or scan the QR code

Entry by invite only

QUICKLY.

Crude oil slumps after Trump signals end to war

London: Crude oil prices lost more than 2 per cent on Wednesday after US President Donald Trump again asserted that the Iran war will end “very quickly”, though investors remain wary about the outcome of peace talks. Brent crude futures fell \$2.58 to \$108.70 a barrel by 1211 GMT. US West Texas Intermediate futures were down \$2.07 at \$102.08. REUTERS

Arabica coffee slips to near 1-1/2 year low



London: Arabica coffee futures fell hovering near a 1-1/2 year low as top grower Brazil's harvest gets under way, while raw sugar gained. Arabica coffee on the ICE fell 1.5 per cent to \$2.5835 per lb at 1004 GMT. The prospect of a bumper crop in top grower Brazil this year is keeping prices on the defensive. Robusta coffee fell 2.1 per cent to \$3,274 a tonne. Raw sugar rose 0.7 per cent to 15.11 cents/lb. White sugar rose 1.2 per cent to \$446.40 a tonne. REUTERS

Copper ticks higher on Chile supply worries

London: Copper prices rose on hopes that the Iran war was nearing an end and after top producer Chile cut its production outlook. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME gained 1.1 per cent to \$13,559 a tonne by 1415 GMT. Nickel rose 0.4 per cent to \$18,880 as investors sought clarity on plans by top producer Indonesia on export policy. Tin prices jumped 4.3 per cent to \$53,850. REUTERS

Global rice prices poised to gain on supply woes

WEATHER, GEOPOLITICAL CONCERNS. Output projected to drop by 5 million tonnes, while offtake may rise by 3.8 mt

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Rice prices in the global market will likely rise due to the balance swinging to a deficit after over a decade and increasing concerns over weather and fertilizer availability due to geopolitical crises, analysts said. “We expect rice prices to maintain upward momentum over the coming quarters, with the 2026 annual average falling within a \$11.7-12.5/cwt (45.36 kg) range, underpinned by rising concerns over weather risks and fertilizer affordability amid the ongoing US-Iran conflict,” said research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions. The US Department of Agriculture (USDA), in its report last week, said global rice production is estimated to decline by 5 million

tonnes (mt) in 2026-27 (September-August) from 537.8 mt in 2025-26. It projected the largest cuts for India (2 mt), Myanmar (1 mt), and the United States (1 mt). World rice consumption is seen up 3.8 mt to 541.4 mt, driven by increases in South Asia, especially India, and sub-Saharan Africa as rice continues to be an important staple. Global stocks are projected to decline 3.6 mt to 192.7 mt with the largest reductions in India, Cambodia, Indonesia and the US. In contrast, China rice stocks are forecast to increase 3 mt to 108 mt, accounting for 56 per cent of global stocks. The Agricultural Marketing Information System (AMIS), an arm of the UN's Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), said global rice prices were mostly

Global rice price trend						
Countries	5% broken white		25% broken white		Parboiled	
	Apr-01	May-20	Apr-01	May-20	Apr-01	May-20
India	337	344	324	332	345	332
Pakistan	347	349	331	334	N.A.	375
Thailand	368	446	346	441	-	-
Vietnam	423	414	415	385	439	459

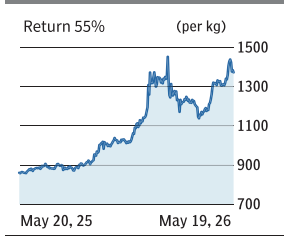
steady currently, reflecting muted demand amid shipping disruptions. “India's export rates are stagnant as market faces slow demand,” it said.

IRAQ STOPS THAI BUY According to the Thailand Rice Exporters Association, the cereal's prices increased by about \$20 a tonne between May 6 and May 13. Vietnam has increased its rates by \$60 since April 1, while India and Pakistan have increased them by less than \$10 a tonne. “We have revised up our

2026 annual average price forecast for CBOT-listed second month rice futures from \$11.2/cwt to \$11.9/cwt. In line with our view that optimism surrounding global supply prospects would ease from end-2025 levels, rice prices trended higher through early 2026, averaging \$10.7/cwt in January, \$11/cwt in February and \$11.4/cwt in March,” said BMI. Prices weakened briefly in April, slipping to \$11.3/cwt as supply fundamentals, particularly expectations of robust global stocks, reasser-

ted themselves. However, prices regained strength through early May, closing at \$12.2/cwt on May 8, the research agency said. AMIS said Iraq had dropped out of the Thai rice market due to the blockage in the Strait of Hormuz. “Thai rice exports are seen recovering in the second half of 2026 if tensions in West Asia ease,” it said. However, shipments from Burma and the US would decline. frequently exceeded 3,000 contracts,” it said. Though there was optimism over global rice production in 2025, the scenario has changed in 2026. BMI said harvest prospects are weak in several major producers, including the US, Thailand, Vietnam, Pakistan and Brazil. “We are cautiously optimistic regarding output for the first (monsoon) crop in India, Vietnam and Thailand, which together account for over 50 per cent of global rice exports, supported by stable near-term weather conditions and sufficient fertilizer availability,” it said. However, inventories, particularly in India, will provide buffer for any problem in the upcoming crop cycle. Governments' policy support to overcome high fertilizer costs would help insulate yields, it said.

COMMODITY CALL. Copper: Buy now at ₹1,340



Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau
Copper futures (₹1,340/kg), after hitting a four-month high of ₹1,414 on May 13, have seen a drop in price. However, the chart shows that the broader uptrend is intact, and we are likely to see a rebound. The May contract, despite declining, continues to trade above the 21-day moving average, which is now at ₹1,318. There is another support below this at ₹1,300, thus making the price range of ₹1,300-1,318 a good base.

‘Higher global prices, tighter imports to boost oilseed output’

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Higher global edible oil prices and tighter import supplies are creating a positive momentum for India's domestic oilseed sector, particularly mustard oil, according to Sanjeev Asthana, President of the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA). In his monthly letter to SEA members on Wednesday, he said domestic edible oil prices were moving in tandem with imported oil prices, thereby supporting mustard prices, which are currently ruling around ₹7,000 per quintal against the minimum support price (MSP) of ₹6,200. Encouragingly, April 2026



KEY CATALYSERS. Sustained price realisations and improving market sentiment may encourage farmers to expand oilseed acreage during the upcoming kharif season

witnessed a record crushing of nearly 16 lakh tonnes (lt) of rapeseed-mustard, helping strengthen domestic edible oil availability while supporting better farmer realisations.

Asthana said the present trend is benefiting farmers through improved incomes and simultaneously reducing the government's burden relating to MSP procurement, storage and carrying costs,

thereby creating a positive situation for farmers, industry and the overall edible oil economy. “Sustained price realisations and improving market sentiment may also encourage farmers to expand oilseed acreage during the upcoming kharif season, supporting domestic production growth over the longer term,” he said. **SUNFLOWER BLOOMS** Stating that sunflower seed is also showing strengthening price alignment with MSP support, he said the government had increased MSP to ₹8,343 per quintal in 2026-27 from ₹7,721 in 2025-26 marking an increase of ₹622 per quintal, thereby strengthening price assurance and encouraging farm-

ers to expand sunflower cultivation alongside mustard. He said that the second all-India castor crop estimate by SEA for the 2025-26 season had reported production at 17.16 lt, which is higher than last year's production of 15.90 lt. Acreage under castor has also increased by around 3 per cent to 8.9 lakh hectares, while productivity improved to 1,928 kg/hectare. “The improved crop outlook reflects better farmer participation and favourable productivity trends, which are expected to support the availability of castor seed and related value-added products during the year,” he said. Referring to the final crop estimates for rapeseed-mustard, Asthana said the total

production of rapeseed-mustard is estimated at 117.6 lt in 2025-26 compared to 115.2 lt last year. **COTTONSEED SUPPLIES** Terming the recently approved Mission for Cotton Productivity (2026-31) as another important development with long-term significance for the edible oil sector, he said higher cotton production would also lead to greater cottonseed availability and enhanced cottonseed oil production. “In an import-dependent economy like India, every additional tonne of domestically produced edible oil contributes meaningfully towards reducing external dependence and strengthening national food security,” Asthana added.

RALLY TO RESUME We expect the contract to resume the rally, either from the current market price or after extending the dip to the above mentioned support band. Once the uptrend resumes, copper futures can retest the previous high of ₹1,414. A breakout of this can open the door for a rally to ₹1,520. On the other hand, if copper futures breach the support at ₹1,300, the downtrend can extend to ₹1,270 and then possibly to ₹1,255. Until the support at ₹1,300 holds, traders are suggested not to consider short positions, whereas participants can use the dip to create fresh longs. **TRADE STRATEGY** Buy copper futures now at ₹1,340. Target and stop-loss can be ₹1,410 and ₹1,300, respectively.

Gold edges up as Treasury yields ease

Reuters

Gold prices edged up as hopes for a resolution to the Iran conflict pressured oil markets, relieving some inflation fears and knocking US Treasury yields from their recent highs. Spot gold gained 0.4 per cent to \$4,499.72 per ounce by 1310 GMT. Prices hit their



lowest in more than seven weeks earlier in the session. US gold futures for June delivery were 0.2 per cent lower at \$4,502.10. Investors are now pricing

in a 48.6 per cent chance the Federal Reserve could raise rates in December, and an 89.6 per cent chance it maintains current rates at its next meeting in June, according to the CME FedWatch tool. Spot silver rose 1.9 per cent to \$75.26 per ounce, platinum gained 0.5 per cent to \$1,932.37, and palladium was down 0.1 per cent at \$1,352.75.

Milma to hike milk price by ₹4 per litre from June 1

Our Bureau
Kochi

The Kerala Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation, popularly known as Milma, has decided to increase the price of milk by ₹4 per litre from June 1, considering the steep increase in production cost borne by the dairy farmers. A proposal in this regard was approved by the meeting

of the Milma Board. Of the enhanced price, ₹3.35 (83.75 per cent) will go to the dairy farmers and 25 paise to (6.25 per cent) to the dairy co-operative societies, said a press release. **BEHIND THE HIKE** The board was of the view that the drastic rise in production cost and low returns had hit dairy farmers in the

State hard, making a price increase inevitable to sustain the sector. Besides the rise in input costs, drought-like conditions in several parts due to the extreme summer and increase in the price of milk procured from neighbouring States to make up the domestic deficit is also a factor for the hike. Also, geopolitical unrest in the Gulf region

and a subsequent rise in fuel prices resulted in a sharp rise in transportation and distribution costs of milk and milk products. The processing, packing and distribution costs had also gone up due to supply chain disruptions and higher price of essential materials. The decision to increase the price of milk arose from the need to ensure dairy

farmers get a remunerative price to sustain them in the vital sector, Milma Chairman KS Mani said. With the new price coming into effect, the procurement price for farmers will go up from ₹40.04 to ₹43.39 per litre. Customers will have to pay ₹28 for a 500 ml packet of homogenised toned milk, which is currently priced at ₹26.

ILL launches Granuvia insecticide for paddy crop

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Insecticides (India) Ltd (ILL) has launched Granuvia, a next-generation, future-ready insecticide. A media statement said Granuvia is recommended for application at 30-35 days after transplanting, a critical stage when paddy crops are the most vulnerable to pests. Its simple broadcasting method makes Granuvia a distinctive solution. It provides up to 60 days of long-duration control against brown plant hopper and also helps farmers manage stem borer.

CONTINUING WOES Pest infestations continue to impact rice productivity across India. Last year, early and prolonged outbreaks of brown plant hopper affected millions of acres across multiple States. In severe cases, brown plant hopper can lead to yield losses ranging from 20-60 per cent. Similarly, stem borer remains a major yield-limiting pest, typically causing 10-30 per cent crop damage. Quoting Rajesh Kumar Aggarwal, MD of ILL, a statement said: “The launch of Granuvia introduces next-gen solution designed to deliver consistent, long-term pest control while improving overall crop health and productivity.”

BOSCH LIMITED										
Registered office: Hosur Road, Adugodi, Bengaluru- 560 030. Website: www.bosch.in, e-mail ID: secretarial.corp@in.bosch.com, Tel: +91 80 67523878 CIN: L85110KA1951PLC000761										
Statement of audited financial results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026										
Particulars	Standalone					Consolidated				
	Quarter Ended		Year Ended			Quarter Ended		Year Ended		
	31.03.2026 Audited	31.12.2025 Unaudited	31.03.2025 Audited	31.03.2026 Audited	31.03.2025 Audited	31.03.2026 Audited	31.12.2025 Unaudited	31.03.2025 Audited	31.03.2026 Audited	31.03.2025 Audited
1. Total Income from operations	57,221	50,855	51,475	2,08,890	1,89,016	57,220	50,855	51,475	2,08,887	1,89,013
2. Profit before tax (before exceptional items)	8,084	7,093	7,785	30,860	27,312	8,084	7,093	7,785	30,857	27,309
3. Exceptional items	-	-	-	5,560	14	-	-	-	5,560	14
4. Profit before tax (after exceptional items)	8,084	7,093	7,785	36,420	27,326	8,084	7,093	7,785	36,417	27,323
5. Net Profit for the period/ year (after tax)	5,685	5,321	5,537	27,703	20,133	5,685	5,321	5,536	27,700	20,130
6. Share of net profit/ (loss) of associates and jointly controlled entity						15	5	(1)	32	22
7. Net profit/ (loss) after taxes and share of profit/ (loss) of associates and jointly controlled entity (5 + 6)	5,685	5,321	5,537	27,703	20,133	5,700	5,326	5,535	27,732	20,152
8. Other comprehensive income (net of income tax)	(3,164)	422	385	(2,312)	2,426	(3,164)	422	385	(2,312)	2,426
9. Total comprehensive income for the period/ year	2,521	5,743	5,922	25,391	22,559	2,536	5,748	5,920	25,420	22,578
10. Paid-up equity share capital (Face value of Rs 10/- each)	295	295	295	295	295	295	295	295	295	295
11. Reserves excluding Revaluation Reserve as per Balance Sheet	-	-	-	1,48,172	1,37,882	-	-	-	1,48,157	1,37,838
12. Earnings per share (in Rupees) (Of Rs 10/- each) (weighted average)										
(a) Basic	192.76	180.43	187.73	939.28	682.62	193.25	180.58	187.66	940.27	683.25
(b) Diluted	192.76	180.43	187.73	939.28	682.62	193.25	180.58	187.66	940.27	683.25
Notes:										
1) The above financial results have been prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards ('Ind AS') notified under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013, read together with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 (as amended).										
2) The above financial results were reviewed by the Audit Committee. These results were approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on May 20, 2026. The audit, as required under Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, has been completed by the Statutory Auditors for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026.										
3) The above is an extract of the detailed format for the audited financial results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026 filed with stock exchanges under Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format for the audited financial results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026 are available on the Company's website (URL: www.bosch.in). The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below										
Place : Bengaluru Date : May 20, 2026										
For and on behalf of Board of Directors Sd/- (Guruprasad Mudlapur) Managing Director										

QUICKLY.

L&T in deal with Open Dhi for secure cloud solutions



Mumbai: Larsen & Toubro's sovereign AI cloud unit, Vyoma, on Wednesday announced a partnership with the Open Dhi Group to host the start-up's enterprise and retail technology platforms on India-based cloud infrastructure. The partnership is aimed at offering enterprises a unified digital stack with guaranteed data residency within India — a growing requirement as regulatory and security concerns around cross-border data flows intensify. Seema Ambastha, Chief Executive of Larsen & Toubro Vyoma, said sovereign and resilient cloud infrastructure would be critical as India moves towards an AI-driven economy, and that the tie-up would allow enterprises to scale on trusted domestic platforms. **OUR BUREAU**

‘Mythos AI can weaponise minor bugs into major cyberattacks’

SIGNIFICANT RISKS. Cloudflare’s findings raise concerns about potential misuse of this advanced technology

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad



MAJOR WARNING. Cloudflare said Mythos Preview represents a massive technological leap forward, but stressed that this breakthrough is a double-edged sword

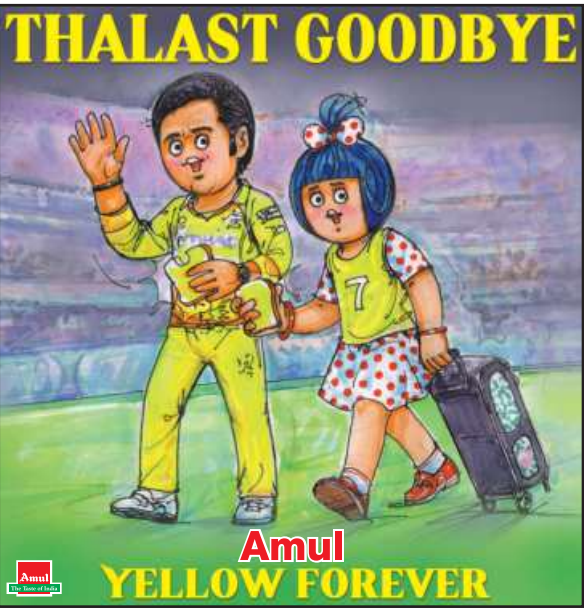
The worst fears of cybersecurity experts about the flipside of advanced artificial intelligence (AI) have come true. A study by global cybersecurity major Cloudflare on Anthropic's new 'Mythos Preview' model has revealed that the AI can autonomously weaponise cyberattacks by chaining minor software bugs into devastating exploits. While evaluating various large language models (LLMs) to identify vulnerabilities in its own infrastructure, Cloudflare discovered a stark distinction in Mythos: its uncanny ability to group separate, low-severity bugs into a single, multi-stage attack path. "A real attack rarely uses one bug. It chains several

small attack primitives together into a working exploit... Mythos Preview can take several of these primitives and reason about how to combine them into a working proof. The reasoning it shows along the way looks like the work of a senior researcher rather than the output of an automated scanner," Cloudflare noted. By stitching these minor, otherwise 'invisible' vulner-

abilities into severe attacks, the model effectively mimics a senior researcher — giving hackers a precise blueprint to automate complex cyberattacks. To test these capabilities, Cloudflare pointed the model at more than 50 of its own code repositories to analyse what it could find and how it operates. While other frontier LLMs did find some of the same underlying

software bugs, they fell short at the finish line. Traditional models typically identify a bug, describe why it matters, and stop — leaving the actual chain unfinished. Mythos, however, successfully closes that gap on its own. **INTERNAL SAFETY** The study also highlighted a bizarre quirk in the AI's behaviour: its internal safety boundaries are completely erratic. In one instance, the model initially refused to conduct vulnerability research on a project, but then agreed to perform the exact same research after an unrelated change was made to the project's environment. In another case, the model identified serious memory flaws in a codebase but refused to write a demonstration exploit to prove it. "The same request, framed differently, got a dif-

ferent answer, and even the same request can produce different outcomes across runs due to the probabilistic nature of the model," the company stated, warning that these organic refusals are not consistent enough to serve as a reliable safety boundary. Cloudflare acknowledged that Mythos Preview represents a massive technological leap forward, making apples-to-apples comparisons to earlier models difficult. However, the company stressed that this breakthrough is a double-edged sword. "We also recognise this topic cuts both ways," Cloudflare warned. "The same capabilities that helped us find bugs in our own code will, in the wrong hands, accelerate the attack side against every application on the Internet."



Dr Reddy’s launches oral semaglutide biosimilar

Our Bureau
Hyderabad



Dr Reddy's Laboratories has launched its oral semaglutide biosimilar, indicated for type 2 diabetes mellitus in the Indian market. Dr Reddy's oral semaglutide is available in tablet form under the brand name Obeda. This launch follows Dr Reddy's recent generic semaglutide injection launches in India and Canada, further establishing the company's position as a full-stack player in GLP-1 therapies. "It can offer convenient, and flexible option which may support earlier treatment initiation," the company said. **COST FACTOR** Dr Reddy's Obeda (semaglutide tablets) is available in 3 mg, 7 mg and 14 mg strengths and recommended for once-daily oral use. It is priced at ₹99, ₹135 and ₹225 per tablet for the 3 mg, 7 mg and 14 mg doses respectively. "The launch of our oral semaglutide for patients with diabetes marks an im-

portant step in our journey to broaden access to advanced diabetes care. We recognise that every patient's journey with diabetes is different. With this launch, we are broadening our GLP-1 portfolio to offer patients more choice and flexibility," MV Ramana, CEO, Global Generics, Dr Reddy's said on Wednesday. "As the products developed and formulated in-house, we are committed to reliable supply and consistent quality for patients in India. As we continue to build a comprehensive GLP-1 portfolio, we are focused on delivering innovation, high-quality, and affordability, translating into meaningful treatment options and better long-term outcomes for people living with chronic metabolic diseases in India and beyond," he added.

RBI revises loan recovery norms after feedback

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has proposed strict curbs on the use of mobile phone disabling tools by lenders, alongside a wider overhaul of loan recovery practices aimed at strengthening borrower protection and tightening oversight of recovery agents. Under the revised draft amendment directions on "Conduct of Regulated Entities in Recovery of Loans and Engagement of Recovery Agents", released on Wednesday, lenders will not be allowed to disable or restrict functions of a borrow-

er's mobile phone as a recovery tool, except in cases where the device itself was financed through a loan. **LOAN ACCOUNT** Even in such cases, lenders can deploy the mechanism only after the loan account becomes 90 days overdue and after issuing multiple notices to the borrower, including a 21-day cure period followed by an additional seven-day notice. The draft norms also bar lenders from disabling essential features, such as internet access, incoming calls, emergency SOS services and public safety notifications. Banks, small finance banks and other lenders will



have to restore device functionalities within one hour once the borrower clears dues, failing which they will have to compensate the borrower at the rate of ₹250 per hour until the issue is rectified. The central bank further said lenders cannot access, retain or use any data stored

on a borrower's mobile device for loan recovery or any other purpose under any circumstances. **REVISED FRAMEWORK** The revised framework introduces several additional borrower protection measures amid concerns over coercive recovery practices by lenders and outsourced recovery agencies. Banks will not be allowed to assign recovery cases to agents if a borrower has lodged a grievance relating to loan dues or recovery proceedings until the complaint is resolved. Lenders will also be required to maintain records of calls made by recovery agents, including record-

ings of conversations with borrowers, for at least six months. Recovery agents can contact borrowers only between 8 am and 7 pm unless specifically authorised otherwise by the borrower. The RBI has also proposed tighter governance standards for recovery agencies, including mandatory due diligence, certification and training requirements for recovery agents, and public disclosure of empanelled recovery agencies on lenders' websites and digital platforms. The proposed directions will come into effect from October 1, 2026, from the earlier July 1 deadline.

No change in UDF at Navi Mumbai airport for FY27

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Passengers travelling to/from Navi Mumbai airport will continue to pay existing user development fees (UDF) for another year. In its tariff order, the Airport Economic Regulatory Authority accepted the airport operator's proposal and retained UDF of ₹620 and ₹1,225 for departing domestic and international passengers for FY27. Incoming passengers will be charged ₹270 and ₹525 respectively. The levies will progressively increase between FY28 and FY30.





THE ALL-NEW
HECTOR
DESIGNED TO Surprise

REVOLUTIONARY PRICE STARTS AT
₹11.99* LAKH

ALL NEW

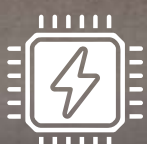
INTRODUCING SEGMENT-FIRST
i-SWIPE
—TOUCH GESTURE CONTROL—



**2-FINGER GESTURE**
to control AC temperature and fan speed.

**3-FINGER GESTURE**
to change music tracks and adjust volume.

**360°**
360° HD CAMERA WITH WHEEL VIEW

**i-SMART**
NOW WITH **SMART BOOST**
(UPGRADED RAM)

**AURA HEX GRILLE**

**AURA SCULPT BUMPERS**

**AURA BOLT ALLOY WHEELS**

**DUAL TONE URBAN TAN INTERIORS**

COMPLETE OWNERSHIP ASSURANCE

**3 YEARS UNLIMITED KM WARRANTY*
3 YEARS UNLIMITED KM ROADSIDE ASSISTANCE
3 FREE LABOUR SERVICES***

**SCAN THE CODE TO BOOK YOUR TEST DRIVE**

BOOK NOW ON WWW.MGMOTOR.CO.IN OR CALL 1800 100 6464

*All prices are ex-showroom India. **In petrol and diesel segment. All variants showcased are top models. Vehicle body colour may differ due to the printing process. Images used in this ad are for representation purposes only. In view of our policy of continuously improving our products, we reserve the right to alter specifications, features and designs without prior notice and without liability. All variants are subject to availability. Please check details with your nearest MG dealership for the latest information. Accessories and features shown in the pictures may not be a part of standard equipment and will differ according to the variant. Available in select cities. *For commercial use cars, coverage up to 3 year/1 lakh km. The warranty coverage for 12V/48V battery, tyres is valid for 1 year while for infotainment system it is valid for 3 years. T&C apply. *For the first 3 scheduled services.

Chennai: MG Chennai Ambattur (08037080866), MG Chennai Anna Salai (08037080865), MG Chennai Chrompet (08037080867), MG Chennai Mount Road (08037080906), MG Chennai OMR (08037080862), MG Chennai Poonamallee (08037080907) **Coimbatore:** MG Coimbatore Avinashi Road (08037080888), MG Coimbatore Mettupalayam Road (08037080903) **Tirupati:** MG Tirupati (08037080879)

Cheil 31772/26

A CH-CE

